SATURDAY
November 14, 2026

INTERNATIONAL EDITION
20 Pages

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 4 • No. 269

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna



MUCH-AWAITED FLAG-OFF

PM unveils Pink Line of Bengaluru Metro

STATES » PAGE 2



TENSION MOUNTS

Four Naga civilians killed in Manipur

NEWS » PAGE 3



CHALLENGES PM

Modi tapped my phone, says Rahul

NEWS » PAGE 4

UNSAFE ZONE

When boys' voices break

As sexually abused boys battle fear, Telangana families seek justice

GROUND ZERO » PAGE 7



YOUNG, HENRY SHINE

New Zealand crushes India in fourth ODI

SPORT » PAGE 14

INSIDE



ICC judges limit Afghan probe to crimes by Taliban

THE HAGUE
Judges at the International Criminal Court have ended the part of the global tribunal's investigation into Afghanistan that could have involved U.S. military personnel, instead limiting the probe to crimes committed by the Taliban, according to court filings released on Friday. » PAGE 12



Tata Sons rejects Noel's request for board meet clips

MUMBAI
Tata Sons has rejected Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata's request for sharing an audio-video recording of proceedings of a board meeting held on September 17 in which N. Chandrasekaran was reappointed as the chairman of the largest conglomerate's holding company. » PAGE 11

Cong. launches website to check SIR deletions

NEW DELHI
The Congress on Friday launched a website where voters can check if their names have been deleted from electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) and register complaints seeking restoration. » PAGE 4

U.S. assures India of tariff edge over competitors

- Both sides working to conclude interim trade agreement by financial year-end, say officials
- 'Much progress on finalising the deal's text was made when U.S. team visited India this month'
- New Delhi has repeatedly insisted on comparative edge as per Trump-Modi statement in February

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

In a significant breakthrough towards the conclusion of the India-U.S. interim trade deal, the U.S. has assured India of a comparative advantage over its competitors once it finalises its tariff structure, a senior official in the Commerce and Industry Ministry said, adding that both sides were working to complete the deal by the end of the current financial year.

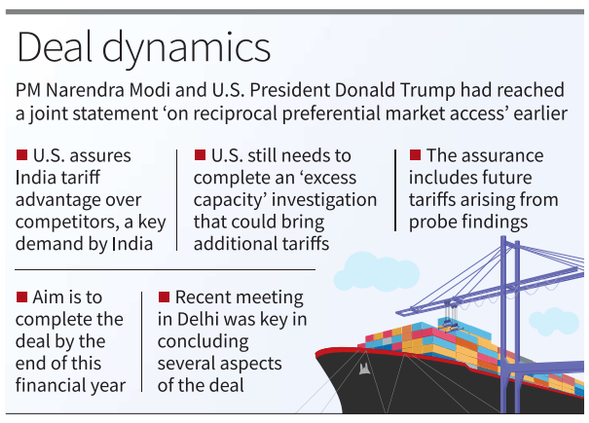
Officials in New Delhi have repeatedly said that India would move ahead with the deal only if it was assured of a comparative advantage, as was agreed to in the February 2026 joint statement between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and U.S. President Donald Trump.

A big deal

"Talks between India and the U.S. are ongoing and the U.S. has assured us of a comparative advantage over our competitor countries," the senior official said on the condition of anonymity as the details of the bilateral discussions have not yet been made public.

This is a significant development because officials, including Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, have repeatedly said that India would move ahead with a deal with the U.S. only if it is assured of a comparative advantage over its competitors.

Separately, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal confirmed that a two-man team from the U.S. visited India earlier this month during which substantial progress was made towards finalising the text of the deal. The February joint statement stated that the U.S. and India "commit to provide each other preferential market access in sectors of respective interest on a sustained basis".



However, since then, the U.S. has imposed additional 10% 'forced labour' tariffs on India, the same as on some of its competitors such as Indonesia, Malaysia, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka.

It is also currently conducting another investigation into India and several other countries related to excess capacity, which could see additional tariffs being levied.

'Unusual clause'

The official, however, said the U.S. assurance of comparative advantage for India takes into account this future tariff.

"The attempt by both sides is to complete the deal by the end of this financial year," the official added. "We have also agreed to a clause that says that if either country changes its tariffs on the other country, then the second country can also modify its commitments under the deal. This was also a part of the February joint statement," the official said.

The official added that such a clause is "not usual" in trade deals that India enters into, but that it had specifically been included in the deal with the U.S.

Separately, Mr. Agrawal said that the talks between the two sides were "on the right track" and that the teams are engaged both in-person and virtually.

"There was a small team from the U.S. that visited India for discussions on customs and trade facilitation in the first week of November," he said. "The discussions went off in a very positive direction. A lot of issues were closed, and there was convergence in a lot of areas."

In addition, he said that the chief negotiators of both sides regularly speak with each other virtually to carry forward the discussions and "iron out some of the language issues or some of the small fixes that remain in the agreement".

Fatal crash



Rescue and recovery: People gather at the site where a passenger minibus collided with a container truck in the Rongajan area of Golaghat district in Assam on Friday. At least 24 people were killed and several injured in the collision. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT/(REPORT ON PAGE 3)

In retaliation, Iran targets U.S. radar in Bahrain

Stanly Johny

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) on Friday said it had "destroyed" a U.S. military early-warning radar in Bahrain, in retaliation for a U.S. strike on a telecommunications tower in Sirik, Iran.

"...in response to the enemy's air attack on a telecommunications tower in Sirik, the IRGC destroyed the early-warning radar of the American aggressors on the island of Bahrain," the IRGC said.

The U.S. denied the claims and said it intercepted two "one-way attack drones" launched at Bahrain by the Guards.

FULL STORY ON » PAGE 12



Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

Exports touch record high as diversification pays off in October

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's merchandise exports rose to an all-time high of $49.5 billion in October 2026, bringing down the country's overall trade deficit, official data released on Friday showed.

While a large part of this growth was due to petroleum products, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said diversification of exports to various locations helped improve the numbers.

India's total exports, including goods and services, stood at $89.99 billion in October 2026, up nearly 30% from last October. The overall trade deficit shrank from $25.1 billion last October to $20.1 billion year-on-year.

"In the month of October, merchandise exports have registered a new peak of $49.47 billion," Mr. Agrawal said. "This is the highest-ever monthly merchandise export value, along with the highest monthly growth of 45.03% in the last five years."

Merchandise imports rose to a record high of $89.35 billion in October 2026, up 16.5% YoY. Total imports stood at $110.1 billion, a 16.6% increase.

According to trade experts, goods exports growing faster than merchandise imports shows that while the rise in global prices contributed to the increase in the value of India's exports, there was also an increase in the underlying export volumes.

"The particularly encouraging part of this growth is that this is not in any particular sector, this is not in any particular geography, it is broad-based across countries and regions," Mr. Agrawal added. "43 of our 50 top export destinations posted positive growth in October this year as compared to 2025."

The data show that India's exports to 12 out of its top 20 export destinations grew by double digits or more. One of the key areas of diversification has been the African continent, with exports to that region growing 44% in April-September 2026 to $31.4 billion.

West Asia trade

India's exports to West Asia increased to $5.7 billion in October 2026, compared to $5.5 billion YoY. Imports from the region stood at $16.2 billion versus $15.99 billion during the period.

India's services trade remained robust in October 2026. Services exports grew to $40.5 billion as compared to $35.2 billion in October last year – a 15% growth.

Services imports grew to $20.7 billion from $17.7 billion over the same period, a 17% increase.

The final services export figure for October, however, will be made available only next month once the Reserve Bank of India releases its figures.

Global disruption of Microsoft services hits Indian firms

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The global disruption of multiple Microsoft services, which began on Thursday and continued late into Friday, affected several Indian businesses' internal communications and customer-facing operations.

In its latest update on Friday, the company said it was making progress in fixing the outage, which has affected email access and workplace applications in businesses, public services, and other organisations across the globe. In India, the disruptions affected businesses from startups to multinational corporations.

A senior executive at a major telecom company in India told *The Hindu* that employees were unable to access emails or send service-disruption alerts to customers. Call-centre traffic also increased, the executive said.

Rahul Ganapathy, CEO of deep tech start-up Atsuya Technologies, said customer emails and scheduled Teams meetings were disrupted, though his company did not rely entirely on Microsoft.

At a Big Four professional services firm in Bengaluru, a senior employee said its internal operations were affected, but added that IT teams were restoring services.

The disruptions also left airlines experiencing customer-support delays.

IndiGo said its email support was affected and advised customers to use 6E Skai, its AI-powered virtual assistant. Akasa Air warned of email support delays and directed passengers to its customer care centre and social media. Air India said flight operations were unaffected, although it rerouted emails.

Separately, India's Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, issued a high-severity advisory on Friday, warning of multiple vulnerabilities in Microsoft products. It flagged an Outlook vulnerability that it said was being actively exploited and urged users to apply security updates.



A fix: Outage affected email access and workplace applications in businesses, public sector, and other firms across the globe. REUTERS

'Recovery under way'

Microsoft identified Exchange Online – described as its cloud-based messaging platform that delivers email, calendar, contacts, and tasks – as the primary service affected. Some Microsoft Graph requests accessing Exchange Online data timed out, affecting dependent features in Teams, Copilot, and SharePoint, the company said. Core Teams messaging and online meetings largely continued normally, it added.

On Friday, Microsoft said recovery was progressing, with improvements in North America and Europe and encouraging signs in Asia-Pacific. Service availability and email delivery were improving, but intermittent access problems and delays could continue, it said, adding that it was working through email backlogs and retained a 48-hour timeout window to protect delayed messages. Service health and capacity had not fully returned to baseline, it said.

The company said it was not aware of any malicious activity causing the disruption and promised that it would publish a detailed report on the root cause and corrective measures after services were restored.

In some countries, government services were affected by the outage.

Singapore's Government Technology Agency and Japanese Ministries reported email disruptions, according to local media reports and official notices.

In Britain, Rachel Harrison of the GMB Union said National Health Service staff handling emergency calls could not refer to patient details as they normally would, creating a "massive backlog". Britain's National Pharmacy Association said the outage delayed prescriptions, *AFP* reported.

Sai Rahul Poruri, CEO of FOSS United, said India should reduce dependence on external technology providers. He called for a more diverse provider ecosystem, citing Germany's approach of allowing individual regions to choose their email providers, many of which use free and open-source software.

Sambratha Shetty, chief operating officer of Synergia Foundation, called for backup channels, multiple providers, and tested continuity plans.

A IN-X

T.N. imposes stock limits on paddy, rice, and pulses

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In rare orders, the Tamil Nadu government on Friday imposed stock limits on paddy, rice, tur dal and pulses held by wholesalers, retailers, rice millers, importers and processors, directing those holding stocks in excess of the prescribed quantities to bring them within the limits by November 16.

The government is taking this measure to prevent hoarding of essential commodities amid concerns regarding inflation.

The restrictions, introduced through the Tamil Nadu Paddy/Rice (Stock Limit) Control Order, 2026, issued by the Cooperation, Food and Consumer Protection Department, will remain in force until January 31, 2027. Likewise the Tamil Nadu Tur and Urad Pulses (Storage Control) Order, 2026, imposed stock limits for a period of three months.

Under the new order, wholesalers have been permitted to hold a maximum stock of 2,000 metric tonne of paddy/rice, while the limit for retailers has been fixed at eight metric tonne for each retail outlet. Big chain retail shops will also be subject to a limit of 8 metric tonne per outlet, with their overall permissible stock capped at 8 metric tonne multiplied by the total number of outlets operated by the chain. Rice millers will not be permitted to hold stocks exceeding their one-month production capacity.

'115 Bharat Summit speakers denied entry into India'

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD


Shashi Tharoor

Senior Congress leader and MP Shashi Tharoor has alleged that 115 of the 315 speakers invited to the second edition of the Bharat Summit in Hyderabad were denied entry into India or had their visas cancelled, "apparently on the instructions of the Union Ministry of Home Affairs".

Mr. Tharoor, who is in Hyderabad for the Bharat Summit, in a post on social media platforms, questioned the legal basis for the action. He pointed out that the summit would conclude on Saturday, making it impossible to reverse the decision in time for the affected participants to attend. "What a shame that a proud democracy has become so insecure that it must stifle any voices it fears will be critical!" he wrote.

Earlier, Congress MP Chamala Kiran Kumar Reddy had also said that nearly 30% of the invitees could not travel to India because of visa-related issues.

When the External Affairs Ministry was asked about Mr. Tharoor's post on visa rejection, Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said: "Visa matters are sovereign functions of any country or any government."

CM slams BJP

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy questioned the BJP's criticism of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's participation in the Bharat Summit, wondering why the party was "spewing venom" against the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha when he was coming to participate in discussions on important issues. Mr. Gandhi is scheduled to participate in the valedictory session on Saturday.

Addressing a press conference in Hyderabad, Mr. Reddy said the BJP should welcome Mr. Gandhi in a democratic spirit and use the international platform to share its views rather than oppose his participation or blindly brand him as anti-national. By denying visas to journalists who questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the government was showing India in a poor light, he said. "Journalists ask questions, and one has the right to respond or not, but not to block them," he said.

He said that portraying the Leader of the Opposition as anti-national was a new political phenomenon, and recalled the tradition of earlier governments involving Opposition leaders in important international engagements.

Modi flags off new Metro line in Bengaluru; CM seeks funds

Bengaluru becomes second city to have a Metro network spanning over 100 km; Shivakumar seeks faster Central clearances for third phase of Namma Metro project, pending for two years

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday flagged off the much-anticipated elevated section of the Pink Line of Namma Metro, a 7.5-km stretch between Kalena Agrahara and Suddagunte Palya in Bengaluru, on Friday.


Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagging off the Namma Metro Pink Line stretch with Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Friday. ANI

With this stretch becoming operational, Bengaluru became the second city after Delhi-NCR to cross the 100-km mark in its Metro network. However, Bengaluru has an operational network of 103.6 km, compared with Delhi-NCR's 416 km.

Namma Metro, which had a network of just 17 km in 2014, had expanded to more than 100 km, the Prime Minister said.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar set a more ambitious target of 500 km of Metro network, which he said "could help address nearly 50% of the city's traffic congestion".

Mr. Shivakumar appealed for more financial contribution and expediting clearances for Namma Metro projects by the Union government.

Mr. Shivakumar said that Karnataka was bearing more than 80% of the financial burden of Metro projects despite the 50:50 Centre-State partnership.

However, Mr. Modi did not respond to the demands on the stage.

Highlighting delays in project approvals, the Chief Minister sought urgent clearance for the proposed Metro Red Line (Phase 3A), pending for nearly two years.

Mr. Modi said the Pink Line will improve connectivity to several key education institutes such as the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore (IIM-B) as well as major business, technology and commercial centres across the city.

He also inaugurated or laid foundation stones for various projects worth over ₹15,600 crore.

CM puts Karnataka's demands before PM

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar shared the stage with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at two events in Bengaluru and Mysuru on Friday, and used both occasions to place a list of demands from the State.

These included clearance for the Mekedatu balancing reservoir project, scrapping of the Kasturirangan Report on the Western Ghats, and immediate drought relief.

Mr. Shivakumar said that the Supreme Court had already delivered its verdict on the Mekedatu project and the legal position was settled. He urged the Centre to grant the final clearances so that the drinking water project can move forward.

However, Mr. Modi did not publicly respond to any of these demands.

Govt.-public dialogue is a must, says Naidu

V. Raghavendra
VISAKHAPATNAM

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu stressed the need for a constant dialogue between governments and the public on issues concerning them – to either meet their expectations or to communicate clearly to them what could be done in a given timeframe.

"As expectations keep growing, conscious efforts should be made to build trust, failing which the resultant trust deficit can lead to public disturbances, like what is happening in Europe and other parts of the world," he said.

In a fireside chat hosted by journalist Palki Sharma at the 31st CII Partnership Summit on Friday, he implied that a fine balance has to be struck between law enforcement and people's right to express their dissent.


C.S. Karnan

Controversial ex-HC judge C.S. Karnan passes away

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

C.S. Karnan, a controversial former judge of the Madras High Court, who was sentenced to six months in prison in contempt proceedings initiated by the Supreme Court during his stint as a judge of the Calcutta High Court in 2017, and was jailed again in 2020 following his retirement, died in Chennai on Friday. He was 71.

During his stint as a Madras High Court judge, Karnan had accused the other judges of ill-treating him because he belonged to a Scheduled Caste. He also had confrontations with former Chief Justices R.K. Agrawal and Sanjay Kishan Kaul over recommendation of names to be elevated as judges of the High Court, and alleged discrimination against SC lawyers.

Around 10 criminal cases were registered against him for reportedly circulating 33 videos on social media abusing sitting as well as former judges, their spouses, lawyers, court staff and others using "vulgar, scandalous, vituperative and obscene" words.

INBRIEF



CPI(M) to strengthen its legal cell to counter fake news

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) has decided to step up the activities of its legal cell in Keralam to counter what it perceives as fake news and targeted spreading of misinformation on social media platforms and public forums to discredit the party and its leaders. A senior CPI(M) leader, who spoke on condition of anonymity, told *The Hindu* that though the party already has a legal cell, it felt the need to further strengthen its activities considering "the volume of misinformation being spread against the party" in recent times.

Real estate businessman hacked to death in Bengaluru

A 39-year-old real estate businessman was hacked to death by two unidentified assailants in broad daylight near the businessman's office in Yelahanka New Town in north Bengaluru on Friday. The deceased's wife, who nearly witnessed the gruesome attack, rushed him to a hospital. However, he died of his injuries. The deceased has been identified as Charan Gowda. Preliminary investigation suggests that the assailants had planned the attack well in advance and had kept track of the deceased's movements, the police said.

8 Army personnel injured as truck overturns in Telangana

Eight Indian Army personnel sustained serious injuries after a military truck carrying 14 soldiers overturned in Chevella in Telangana on Friday. The accident occurred when the personnel were travelling from the Golconda Army camp towards Shabad. A trainee soldier was reportedly driving the vehicle when it went out of control, hit a divider and overturned. The injured were shifted to a hospital in Golconda for treatment.

Sonia's memoir revisits her Coorg ties and electoral debut from Ballari

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU


Copies of Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's memoir, *Belonging*, displayed at a bookstore in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

An arecanut plantation in Karnataka was among the places that caught the interest of Sonia Gandhi's father, Stefano Maino, during his visits to India. Alongside a power project in Keralam and a factory in Maharashtra, it was one of the places he chose to see beyond the usual tourist circuit, writes Sonia Gandhi in her recently released memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*.

From her father's visits to India and the memories of people who became part of her family life to the electoral contests in which she and her mother-in-law, Indira Gandhi, were involved, Karnataka finds mention in different parts of the memoir.

Another person from Karnataka who figures in Ms. Gandhi's memories was Amie Crishna, who hailed from Coorg and served as one of Indira Gandhi's personal secretaries.

Amie, Ms. Gandhi writes, would also tell her about Coorg, its people and their valour, and its food, including "curries made with the avocados that grew wild there".

The State also figures in the electoral journeys of both Indira Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi.

Ms. Gandhi recalls how the coffee-growing constituency of Chikkamagaluru gave her mother-in-law a route back to the Parliament in November 1978, after her defeat in Rae Bareli in the 1977 Lok Sabha election in the aftermath of the Emergency.

Karnataka also became the setting for Ms. Gandhi's own electoral debut. In 1999, she contested the polls from both Amethi in Uttar Pradesh and Ballari in Karnataka.

The memoir also recounts how her daughter, Priyanka Gandhi, accompanied her when she filed her nominations in both constituencies and joined her on the campaign trail in Ballari.

Minister's remarks disprove CM's claim on GNA deal: Pinarayi

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Reiterating his demand for a judicial inquiry headed by a High Court judge into the controversy surrounding the cancellation of the GNA power purchase deal, Keralam Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said on Friday that all the claims made so far by Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan regarding the power contract have been proved factually incorrect, going by Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph's statements.

"With the Minister himself openly stating that the KSEB did not exert pressure to procure power and that the GNA contract is unfeasible, the Chief Minister's credibility has been completely shattered. The Chief Minister, who had previously dismissed with contempt the Opposition's allegation that GNA was merely an intermediary agency, rather than a power producer or a licensed trader, has now been corrected by his own Minister. The Electricity Minister's remarks substantiate our position that the Chief Minister only withdrew from the contract after the Opposition caught the irregularities red-handed," said Mr. Vijayan.

Mr. Joseph on Friday said there were no differences between him and the Chief Minister over the power purchase agreement with GNA.

NSS chief signals thaw in relations with Keralam CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The NSS chief said misunderstandings between him, CM had been resolved

Signalling a thaw in his frosty relationship with Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, Nair Service Society (NSS) general secretary G. Sukumaran Nair has invited him to inaugurate the 150th birth anniversary celebrations of founder Mannathu Padmanabhan in Kottayam.

Mr. Nair said on Friday that he had invited the Chief Minister over the phone to participate in the inaugural ceremony and also sent a formal invitation letter. Mr. Satheesan had expressed his willingness to participate, he said. Mr. Nair added that misunderstandings between them had been resolved. "The Chief Minister explained the circumstances under which he made the statement that he would not seek the support of community organisations...," he said.

Karnataka to launch health programme to address menopause-related concerns

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka Health Department will launch 'Ruthu Taare', a three-month pilot project of its mid-life women's health and menopause programme, in Dakshina Kannada, covering women aged 35 and above.

Actor and former MP Ramya has been appointed the brand ambassador of the programme.

Health Minister U.T. Khader said the initiative seeks to address health concerns associated with perimenopause, menopause and post-menopause, which were often dismissed as a natural part of ageing.


The initiative will provide screening, clinical assessment, counselling and treatment.

"Women's health does not end with motherhood, and menopause should never be a journey women are expected to endure in silence. Sleepless nights, hot flashes, joint pain, weakening bones, anxiety and emotional changes are real health concerns. They deserve understanding, timely diagnosis and proper medical care," he said.

The initiative will provide screening, clinical assessment, counselling, treatment and referral services. Women will also be given a Mid-Life Health Card.

The District Health and Family Welfare Officer, Dakshina Kannada, has been directed to begin preparatory work, including mapping Primary Health Centres (PHCs), Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, taluk and district hospitals, and designated medical colleges.

ASHAs, ASHA mentors, community health officers, medical officers and nursing personnel will be involved in implementing the programme.

Screening for hypertension, diabetes, obesity and other cardiometabolic risk factors will be integrated with existing non-communicable disease services. Breast and cervical cancer screening will also be facilitated.

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X

LeT operative, two foreigners linked to Kulgam attack: police

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Jammu and Kashmir Police have identified Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) operative Mohammad Lateef Bhat, 22, and two foreign accomplices as the group behind an attack on the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) in Kulgam on Thursday that left three personnel injured.

Senior police officers said they have "credible leads" pointing to the involvement of Bhat, a carpenter from Kulgam. He is also wanted for two attacks in Anantnag and Kulgam last July that left a police officer and two workers from Chhattisgarh dead.

Officers said they are examining Bhat's digital footprint, and multiple leads point to two foreigners being involved in the attack. The police have ruled out the use of a motorbike in the attack as evidence suggests "the attackers ran through a marshy area to escape". They also used AK-47 rifles and fired from close range.

The "prompt and effective response of the security forces prevented the attackers from inflicting casualties and damage on the scale they had intended". The retaliation by the CRPF personnel forced the group to retreat from the spot without achieving their desired objectives, officers said.

The security agencies said Bhat made a daring escape after the Anantnag attack in July this year. He kept his automatic weapon in a sack (usually used by labourers) and boarded a passenger bus from the main Anantnag town to escape after killing the police officer.

Meanwhile, security agencies have questioned three suspected LeT workers. The police are investigating whether an LeT worker "provided shelter and recced the attack site" for the group.

A National Investigation Agency (NIA) team visited the Kulgam site on Friday to gather evidence and establish the attackers' mode of operation.

Four Naga civilians killed in Manipur highway ambush

The assailants ambushed two vehicles and opened fire; Kuki groups deny any involvement; the attack comes a day after a Kuki woman died and two Kuki men got injured in a similar incident

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Unidentified gunmen killed four Naga civilians, including a mother and her son, on National Highway 202 in Manipur's Ukhrul district on Friday.

The assailants ambushed the vehicles – a hatchback and a pickup – in New Haven around 1 p.m. The location is in the Litan area, the epicentre of conflict between the Kuki and Naga communities since February this year.

The deceased were identified as Kapangkhui R.S., her son Haoleila R.S., Khanmila Keising, and August Ngalung. The first two victims were from Shangshak village and the latter two were from Tashar village; both villages are in Ukhrul district.

A Manipur Police statement said the miscreants opened fire on the two vehicles, and all four victims died on the spot.


Additional security personnel have been deployed to reinforce safety and prevent any more untoward incidents. FILE PHOTO

"Additional security forces, comprising Manipur Police, BSF (Border Security Force), Army, and Assam Rifles, have been rushed to the area to reinforce security and prevent any further untoward incidents. Search operations have been launched in and around the area of the incident to trace and apprehend those involved," the statement read.

Officials said the site of the attack is about 35 km from Ukhrul town and 6 km short of Litan. A blockade imposed by a Kuki organisation had stopped vehicular movement on the highway until August.

The government provides security escorts for vehicles travelling between Imphal and Ukhrul from Litan in both directions.

Friday's ambush came a day after a Kuki woman was killed and two Kuki men were injured in a similar firing incident in the adjoining Kangpokpi district. Ukhrul has a Naga majority while Kangpokpi has a Kuki majority.

'Impartial probe'

Naga organisations said Kuki armed groups could be behind the attack. However, Kuki groups categorically denied any involvement. Several Kuki civil society organisations condemned the killings of the Naga civilians and demanded an impartial probe into the incident.

More than 65 people have died since an alleged drunken brawl in February triggered the Kuki-Naga conflict in Manipur.

Manipur probe panel gets sixth extension; no sign of report yet

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The report is awaited even as the ethnic conflict has now spread to Kuki and Naga communities

The three-member Commission of Inquiry, set up by the Union Home Ministry to investigate the 2023 Manipur ethnic violence, was given a sixth extension on Friday.

The Ministry notified that the commission, which was constituted on June 4, 2023, "shall submit its report to the Central government as soon as possible but not later than May 20, 2027".

More than 300 people have been killed in the ethnic violence that erupted between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei people on May 3, 2023. Around 60,000 people have been displaced.

The probe panel's report is awaited even as the ethnic conflict has now spread to the Kuki and Naga communities. Since February this year, more than 60 people have been killed in Naga-Kuki clashes.

The commission is now headed by former Supreme Court judge Balbir Singh Chauhan, after Ajai Lamba, the former Chief Justice of the Gauhati High Court, resigned as the chairperson in February this year.

11,000 affidavits

Manipur's Commission of Inquiry has received around 11,000 affidavits.

President's rule was imposed in the State on February 13, 2025 and on February 4 this year, a new Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh took oath, ending Central rule.

The inquiry commission is mandated to probe the causes, extent of violence and riots targeting members of different communities, the sequence of events, and whether there were any lapses or dereliction of duty on the part of any of the responsible authorities and individuals.

Students among 24 killed as truck collides with minibus in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Twenty-four people, including college students, were killed when a minibus collided head-on with a container truck at Rangajan near Kaziranga National Park in eastern Assam's Golaghat district on Friday.

Officials said 39 people, including the driver, were on board the minibus when the accident occurred around 1 p.m. on National Highway no. 715. The spot is about 230 km east of Guwahati.


People carry an injured boy to safety after the accident on a highway bordering Kaziranga. AFP

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma confirmed the number of casualties and said that several critically injured persons were undergoing treatment at the Jorhat Medical College and Hospital in the adjoining Jorhat district and the Civil Hospital in Golaghat, the district headquarters.

Of the 15 injured, some were battling for their lives. "Our foremost priority now is to make sure the injured receive the best possible medical care without delay. (Panchayat and Rural Development) Minister Atul Bora, who was at the site, is overseeing the relief arrangements. I pray for the swift recovery of the injured and for strength for the bereaved families," the Chief Minister said, adding that he would visit the place on Saturday.

"Some of the passengers died on the spot. They included some college students," Mr. Bora, also the local MLA, said.

Officials said the exact number of students who died was being ascertained. Officials suspected that overspeeding by the minibus, travelling from Golaghat to Nagaon in central Assam, caused the accident.

A dashcam clip from the container truck heightened the suspicion.

Speed limits are enforced near animal corridors along the 60-km stretch of the National Highway abutting Kaziranga National Park.

A man who identified himself as the truck's driver said he was on his way to Dibrugarh from Tezpur when the minibus hit his vehicle. He and his companion escaped with minor injuries.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the deaths and said, "An ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh from PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each of those who lost their lives. The injured would be given ₹50,000."

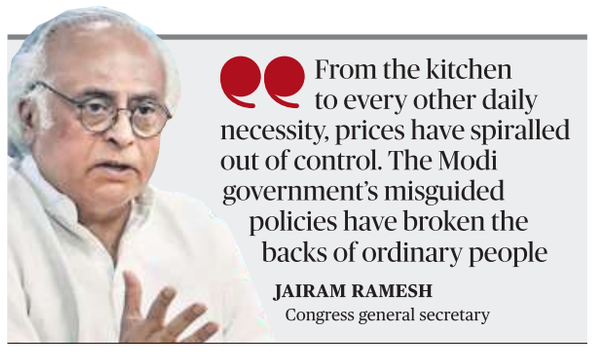
Congress slams Modi govt. over soaring cost of living

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday accused the Narendra Modi government of failing to contain the rising prices of essential commodities, saying the country was witnessing *"mehengaai ka bhuchaal"* (earthquake of inflation) instead of "*Amrit Kaal*" (period of prosperity).

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh, sharing media reports on his X handle, said the rising costs of food and everyday necessities was putting an increasing burden on household budgets.

"Under the Modi government, inflation is no longer just a '*daayan*' (witch); it has become an uninvited guest, devouring every household's budget. From the kitchen to every other daily necessity, prices have spiralled out of control. The Modi government's misguided policies have broken the backs of ordinary people," Mr. Ramesh said.



He claimed that retail inflation had touched a two-year high of 6.09%, while food inflation had risen to 8.94%. Citing price rises, he said onions had become 116% more expensive, garlic 60% and ginger 48%, and that prices had risen across 11 of the 12 consumption categories, impacting households far greater than what official figures indicated.

From flour, cooking oil, ghee, milk, and pulses to soap, the cost of everyday essentials had risen, he said, adding that companies were also considering reducing the quantity of products rather than raising prices further.

Mr. Ramesh also flagged the possibility of interest rate increases. "Now, there are also fears of interest rate hikes, which would make both borrowing and living even more expensive for ordinary people. This is not an Amrit Kaal; it is an inflationary earthquake," he said.

Conference urges BRICS to focus on mental health

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The 11th Together Against Stigma (TAS) conference, being organised by George Institute for Global Health in collaboration with AIIMS Delhi, and UNICEF, has called for stronger cooperation among BRICS countries to combat mental health stigma and discrimination, with a focus on improving access to inclusive mental healthcare for children, adolescents, and young people.

They identified youth participation, and evidence-based policy reforms as key priorities. Network of Centres of Excellence were also identified as platforms for sharing research and expertise.

Being held at AIIMS, New Delhi, from November 12 to 14, the conference is the first edition hosted in a Global South country.

UAPA ban on Zakir Naik's IRF extended for five years

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union Home Ministry has extended the ban against "Islamic terror-preacher" Zakir Naik's Islamic Research Foundation (IRF) under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for another five years, a government notification said.

The IRF was first declared an "unlawful association" in 2016, which was extended for another five years in 2021.

Naik left India in 2016 and was granted permanent residency by Malaysia. Despite India seeking Naik's extradition, Malaysia is yet to comply with the request.

India's bid at the Interpol to open a Red Corner Notice against Naik, to stop his free movement across the world, has also not materialised.

"If the unlawful activities of the IRF are not curbed and controlled immediately, it will take the opportunity to continue its subversive activities and re-organise its activists who are still absconding and disrupt the secular fabric of the country by polluting the minds of the people by creating communal disharmony," the Ministry said in a statement.

'Fostering hostility'

"Led by fugitive terror preacher Dr. Zakir Naik, the organisation has been involved in sinister anti-India designs, including inciting communal hatred, fostering hostility and promoting terrorism. The group has been found to be propagating a venomous ideology of terrorism and separatism, instigating violent unrest, encouraging the regrouping of absconding terrorists and fomenting communal discord," the office of Union Home Minister Amit Shah said in a post on social media platform X.

The IRF has been indulging in activities which are prejudicial to the security of the country, and have the potential of disturbing peace and communal harmony and disrupting the secular fabric of the country, the Ministry said.

The Union government is of the opinion that the IRF and its members, particularly, the founder and president of the IRF, Dr. Zakir Abdul Karim Naik alias Dr. Zakir Naik, has been encouraging and aiding its followers to promote, on grounds of religion, disharmony or feelings of enmity, hatred or ill-will between different religious communities and groups which are prejudicial to the integrity and security of the country, the Ministry said. He had been making radical statements and speeches to millions of people worldwide, they added.

The notification has been made under Section 3 (1)(3) of the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act.

Cancer patient held for planting hijack threat on aircraft

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A 56-year-old man with colon cancer was arrested on Thursday for planting a hoax threat on a Mumbai-bound Air India flight from Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose International Airport in Kolkata on Wednesday.

A handwritten note with a hijacking threat was found in the washroom of AI 2772 only a few minutes before the flight was to take off, according to the police. All 105 passengers were immediately offboarded and a search operation was initiated, but nothing suspicious was found.

Meanwhile, the police started questioning the passengers and also collecting samples of their handwriting.

"We noticed an imprint of a rusty button on the slip in which the threat was written. It was assumed that it could be from a wallet. So, we also checked everyone's wallets thoroughly," Prabhakar Adhikari, Inspector, airport police station, said. Both the handwriting and the wallet was matched with one passenger, Partha Pratim Nandi. He was detained immediately for questioning.

During the interrogation on Thursday, he confessed that he had written the message.

"*Prima facie*, he was going to Mumbai, from where he was supposed to take his next flight to South Africa, where he had been selected for a new job. But both he and his wife have been suffering from cancer for a long time. He did not want to go far away from his wife and therefore came up with the idea to cancel the entire flight," the inspector said.

Following the confession, the police arrested him immediately.

India-Bangladesh consular talks to be held on mutually convenient date, says govt.

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

The fifth round of the India-Bangladesh consular dialogue will be held on a "mutually convenient date", the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday.

Speaking to the media during the bi-weekly media briefing, Randhir Jaiswal, official spokesperson of the MEA, reiterated that India seeks to build "positive, constructive and forward-looking" relations with Bangladesh.

"The next round of the India-Bangladesh Consular Dialogue, which will also take up matters relating to the Revised Travel Arrangement, will be held on a mutually convenient date. India remains ready to discuss all bilateral issues with Bangladesh through these existing mechanisms, including at the technical level," Mr. Jaiswal said.


Randhir Jaiswal

The Hindu had reported on Thursday about the postponement of the consular talks that were to be held on November 17 and 18.

"India desires a positive, constructive, and forward-looking relationship with Bangladesh. Accordingly, initiatives have been taken and meetings held under our structured mechanisms in such areas as trade, railways, water resources and border management, among others," said Mr. Jaiswal.

Diplomatic sources had indicated that the postponement was because of the spike in tensions in view of the proposed return of former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina to Bangladesh. Ms. Hasina has been in India since August 5, 2024 and she has said that she would return to Dhaka in December.

The two sides started consular dialogue in 2017 to strengthen people-to-people contact by having a regular channel of communication on consular, visa and mutual legal assistance cooperation matters. Four rounds of consular dialogue were held during the rule of the Awami League in Dhaka.

The MEA said the fourth round in May 2024 discussed issues such as "visa matters, repatriation, mutual legal assistance treaty cases, etc".

Congress launches website for voters to check SIR deletions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


K.C. Venugopal

The Congress on Friday launched a website where voters can check if their names have been deleted from electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) and register complaints seeking restoration.

Announcing the initiative, Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said the website, *Iamvoterakshak.in*, would allow citizens to verify their names and formally protest against deletions by applying for restoration.

Before the announcement, Mr. Venugopal chaired a video conference with AICC general secretaries, in-charge leaders, Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) presidents, AICC secretaries and observers to review the party's ongoing "Vote *Bachao*, *Desh Bachao*" campaign against alleged electoral irregularities.

'Vote Rakshaks'
As part of the next phase of the campaign, Congress workers will function as "Vote Rakshaks" and visit every polling booth to verify deletions from electoral rolls. "The mission to stop 'vote *chori*' continues in every single corner of India," Mr. Venugopal said, asserting that the Congress would continue its campaign until the integrity of the electoral system was restored.

The party will organise village-level *chaupals* across the country by December 15, where names deleted during the SIR exercise will be read out, Mr. Venugopal said.

The PCCs will organise large-scale "Samvidhan Raksha" marches in their respective States on November 26, Constitution Day.

Rahul says his phone with proof against Modi is being tapped

Opposition leader says PM's political career will be finished if they were to have a debate on who is an anti-national, as it will expose who is being controlled by foreign powers; he adds that there are much more details stored in the phone

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

> You did not let me talk on the farm Bills, vote *chori*, SIR, China, on [General] Naravane's book, [Jeffrey] Epstein. I want a one-on-one debate. I don't want a debate entailing long speeches
>
> **RAHUL GANDHI**
> Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha



Accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi of tapping his phone, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Friday dared Mr. Modi to have a debate with him on who was an anti-national.

The Prime Minister's "political career will be over" if he accepted the invitation to debate as he [Mr. Gandhi] had "evidence" against Mr. Modi on his phone, the Congress leader claimed.

"The Prime Minister's political career will be over if he comes and debates with me. He knows that and I know that. He keeps calling me anti-national. I want to show the nation who exactly is anti-national, who is controlled by whom and since when, and he knows that truth," the Congress leader said in a video on his Instagram and X handles.

Replying to a question during an 'Ask Me' session on Instagram on why he was insisting on a public debate when the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has said the exchange could take place in Parliament, Mr. Gandhi said he was not allowed to speak in the House and even his microphone was switched off.

One-on-one debate
"You did not let me talk on the farm Bills, vote *chori* (theft), SIR, China, on [General] Naravane's book, [Jeffrey] Epstein. I want a one-on-one debate. I don't want a debate entailing long speeches," Mr. Gandhi said. "I want that Narendra Modi makes allegations against me and I do the same to him. He can come. There will be a table. On one side, there will be Narendra Modi*ji*, and on the other side, it will be me."

Mr. Gandhi suggested that business tycoon Gautam Adani or Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat could become the judge for the debate. "But I guarantee that the Prime Minister will not remain the PM after a one-on-one debate with me," he said.

"The proof is here," Mr. Gandhi said in response to another question on what proof he had to back his allegations. "The Prime Minister knows it because he taps my phone. The moment he comes for the debate, one-on-one debate, everybody will know who is controlled by foreign powers, who is an anti-national, and since when he has been an anti-national, and lots of other details are on my phone," the Congress leader added.

'Fear in Modi's mind'
"Notice something: there is a little fear in his [Modi's] mind because he is no longer commenting about me, he is no longer attacking me, he is being very, very careful. There is a reason for it, guys," Mr. Gandhi said.

The Opposition leader took a swipe at the Prime Minister over his Deepavali *milan* (gathering) programme at the BJP headquarters with representatives of the media.

"Modi*ji*, even at your own *godi* media's Diwali gathering, you used a teleprompter? The people are yours, the stage is yours, the whole environment is yours, yet you still need a script. Looks like the pressure got to you. Anyway, no worries. Bring a teleprompter to a debate with me too, and seat a judge of your choice as well. Just show up, that's all. The country wants to know – who is the real traitor?" Mr. Gandhi said.

'Great book'
In response to another question on why the BJP was talking so much about *Belonging: A Journey Of Love*, the memoir by his mother and Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi, Mr. Gandhi said it was "great book" and they were all reading it.

"They can't resist reading it and then they have got to comment on it. A lot of them actually secretly like her and they think she is fantastic, but unfortunately they can't say it. The other thing is – all you *bhakts*, please, please keep commenting on the book because the more you comment, the better it does," Mr. Gandhi said.

'Delink poll roll status and welfare benefits'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A civil society group has written to Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh over his reported remarks that voter ID will replace Aadhaar for identifying beneficiaries of social welfare programmes, urging the government to assure the public that electoral-roll status will not become a condition for receiving welfare benefits.

The letter from Citizens for Fraternity Forum was signed by former Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Najeeb Jung, ex-AMU Vice-Chancellor Zameer Uddin Shah and former diplomat Ashok Kumar Sharma, among others.

"We strongly believe that no eligible citizen should be denied welfare benefits merely because they do not possess a voter ID, their name is not included in the electoral rolls, or biometric authentication fails," the letter said. The group urged the government to issue a public assurance that electoral-roll status will not become a condition for receiving welfare benefits.

Owaisi-Azad tie-up won't have impact on INDIA bloc prospects, say Congress, SP

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW


Asaduddin Owaisi addresses a joint press conference with ASP(KR)'s Chandrashekhar Azad in Lucknow on Thursday. ANI

The Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Congress on Friday said the alliance between the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) and the Aazad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) will not have any impact on voters from social groups facing injustice under the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Uttar Pradesh. They added that voters were aware that only the INDIA bloc was capable of defeating the BJP decisively.

"Even before the announcement of AIMIM-ASP (KR) alliance, people were expecting that the BJP will try to divide the votes of Dalits, Muslims, backwards and progressive sections of society. But we believe people are fully aware that what is real end game of any such front. People across sections of the society are fully behind the INDIA alliance, and are waiting for Assembly polls to defeat the anti-people BJP government," said Shahnawaz Alam, national secretary, Congress.

The SP said Dalits and Muslims were cautious about the sudden, unnatural alliance.

"The alliance of AIMIM and ASP (KR) has formed the Samajik Parivartan Morcha (Front for Social Change) to attract anti-incumbency votes from the BJP government, primarily among Scheduled Castes and Muslims. While the front might shift 2% to 3% of the votes away from the BJP, Dalits and Muslims at the ground level remain cautious about the intent and viability of this sudden, unnatural alliance. Dalits and Muslims are part of the Samajwadi Party's socio-political platform (PDA). Ultimately, this arrangement is unlikely to alter the election prospects of the INDIA alliance," said Sudhir Panwar, a senior SP leader.

On Thursday, AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi and ASP (KR) chief Chandrashekhar Azad announced a political alliance for the 2027Assembly election, a first declared non-National Democratic Alliance (NDA), non-INDIA bloc political front in Uttar Pradesh, with both parties considered marginal players eyeing to consolidate Scheduled Caste (SC) and minority voters in the politically crucial state. The alliance named Mr. Azad as its chief ministerial candidate.

Bengal CM says CID to probe housing scheme 'scam'

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA


Suvendu Adhikari

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday alleged that around 57,000 fake beneficiaries had fraudulently applied for the Banglar Bari Rural Housing Scheme, out of which 12,000 such beneficiaries had received government funds during the previous Trinamool Congress government.

About 1,000 of the beneficiaries had returned the money fraudulently obtained by the government, and the remaining 11,000 ineligible recipients had till November 30 to return government funds or face legal action, Mr. Adhikari said.

"We want to constitute an SIT (Special Investigation Team) and have the CID investigate the matter. If there has been any lapse at the official level, action will be taken," Mr. Adhikari said at an event at the State Secretariat where the West Bengal government transferred ₹4,201 crore as the second instalment of housing assistance to more than 7.17 lakh beneficiaries across the State.

Mr. Adhikari tried to assure the people of the State that his government would continue to support genuine beneficiaries whose houses remained incomplete, irrespective of political affiliation, caste or religion.

"The previous government claimed that the second instalment would not be paid if there was a change of government. We have proved that wrong," the CM said. "We do not discriminate on the basis of political affiliation, caste or community," he said.

The scheme to provide housing for the rural poor was named Banglar Bari by the erstwhile Trinamool Congress government. The BJP government renamed it to Paschim Banga Awas.

War of words in U.P. over CM's remark on bulldozer becoming 'brand' of State

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW


Supporters with earth-mover bulldozers attend a public meeting of Yogi Adityanath in Sidharth Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, in 2022. PTI

Criticising Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's comment inviting industries to manufacture bulldozers in the State, the Opposition parties on Friday said a symbol of injustice and oppression could never be a brand of the State.

"For a long time, U.P. CM has been synonymous with making controversial statements. The remark that the 'bulldozer' has now become a brand of Uttar Pradesh is unacceptable as in the State, bulldozer is used on poor and people hailing from marginalised communities, mostly Dalits and minorities. Bulldozer is a symbol of injustice and a weapon of oppression. Only a divisive leader will make such remarks. Under the garb of zero-tolerance policy towards crime, injustice is being committed against a large section of population," Anil Yadav, a senior Congress leader, said.

The Samajwadi Party alleged the bulldozer is selectively used against political opponents and the poor. "The Chief Minister gives protection to anti-social elements hailing from dominant, feudal communities, while using bulldozer against opponents. We saw how Azam Khan Saheb is being subjected to injustice," SP spokesperson Ameeque Jamei said.

Addressing the groundbreaking ceremony of CNH Industrial's new tractor manufacturing plant on Thursday, Mr. Adityanath said, "The rule of law has replaced mafia rule in Uttar Pradesh. The zero-tolerance policy towards crime and criminals, coupled with bulldozer action, has transformed the State into a major investment destination. The bulldozer has now become a brand of Uttar Pradesh. If companies manufacture bulldozers and tractors here, their demand will automatically rise in India and abroad."

Commending the public representatives of the Jewar region, he said, "The area, which was once notorious for crime and gun violence, has emerged as one of India's finest investment destinations and a 'jewel' of the country. With the development of Noida International Airport and YEIDA [Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority], the entire region is evolving into a major industrial, economic and logistics hub."

Jharkhand Congress MLA accused of rape by minor, booked

Press Trust of India
RANCHI

Jharkhand Congress MLA Bhushan Bara was booked on Friday after a 15-year-old girl, who worked as a domestic help at his official residence, accused him of rape, police said.

The girl, who is from Simdega district, lodged a complaint at a police station, alleging that Mr. Bara had raped her at his residence on August 5, following which she became pregnant. She later learnt during a medical examination that she suffered a miscarriage, it was alleged. The girl said she was brought to Ranchi by the MLA's family in May on the promise of being enrolled in a school, but was instead made to do domestic work.

Hatia DSP Neeraj Kumar said, "We have registered a case against the MLA from the Simdega Assembly seat under the POCSO Act and the Juvenile Justice Act. The victim has been sent to Sadar Hospital for a medical examination."

Mr. Bara denied the allegations, calling them "completely false and misleading".

Opposition calls for wider consultations by FCRA panel

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


BJP MP Sanjay Jaiswal, the Chairperson of the Joint Parliamentary Committee, and other members at a meeting last month. FILE PHOTO

The Parliament's Joint Committee reviewing the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, met 25 organisations in a single day's sitting on Thursday, as it rushes to finalise its report in time for the upcoming Parliament session that is likely to begin on November 30.

Opposition members, in a letter to the panel Chairperson and BJP leader Sanjay Jaiswal, said the committee should hold wider consultations with stakeholders across the country, arguing that the consequences of the Bill would be felt most acutely at the level of the individual parish, school, college, hospital, orphanage, and welfare home.

"The vast majority of these stakeholders have neither the means nor a realistic opportunity to travel to New Delhi and place their views before the committee," Opposition members wrote. The letter was signed by six members – Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam's P. Wilson; Congress's Christopher Tilak, Captain Viriato Fernandes and Muhammed Hamdullah Sayeed; and the Samajwadi Party's Zia Ur Rehman Barq and Javed Ali Khan.

Competing arguments
The invitees for Thursday's meeting included the National Council of Churches in India and other Christian organisations, which strongly opposed the legislation, arguing that it would hamper their charitable work.

At least five RSS-linked organisations were also invited to present their views. They argued in favour of the legislation, calling it a key step towards regulating foreign funding.

The Christian groups argued that, in the name of tighter monitoring of foreign funding, many vulnerable groups that receive support from charitable organisations would be denied help.

They also argued that it impinges on their religious freedom. The Opposition members have requested that the Christian groups submit details of the charitable organisations they run that are dependent on foreign funding.

The RSS-linked organisations called for tighter provisions, including listing FCRA violations as a scheduled offence under the Prevention of Money-Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA), which is a core criminal law aimed at combating terror financing and money laundering.

Those who submitted their opinions before the committee included Apostles Methodist Church, National Council of Churches in India, Evangelical Church of India, Jesus Redeems, Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram, Akhil Bhartiya Adhivakta Parishad, and Rashtriya Sewa Bharati, among others. Opposition members questioned how the RSS-linked groups that were invited qualified as stakeholders.

The Bill was introduced in Lok Sabha on March 25 this year and referred to the panel on August 12, following demands from the Opposition, which alleged that certain provisions of the legislation were highly objectionable.

INBRIEF



Devotees gather at ghats as Chhath festival begins in Bihar

Bihar's Chhath festival began on Friday with Nahay-Khay, the first day of the four-day celebration. Large numbers of devotees gathered at river ghats, including the Ganga, to take a holy dip and collect water. This year, out of 103 ghats, 90 in the State capital, Patna, has been declared safe for the devotees where they can perform the puja. However, 13 have been declared unsafe. Chhath Puja will also be celebrated in over a dozen parks across Patna city, including the lake at the zoo. To ensure that those observing the festivities face no difficulties, the respective parks are undergoing thorough cleaning. Lighting installations and enhancement of other essential facilities are also under way.

M.P. man dies after bomb offered as rasgulla explodes

A 35-year-old man died in Dindori district of Madhya Pradesh safter a crude bomb disguised as a sweet treat exploded in his mouth, the police said on Friday. The victim, identified as Rajendra Barotiya, was offered the explosive by an acquaintance who presented it as rasgulla at Padariya Chhanta village on Tuesday. Locally known as a "*suar mar* bomb" (pig bomb), it is made using dough and gunpowder to kill wild boars. The Additional Superintendent of Police, Dindori, told *The Hindu* that after the bomb exploded, Barotiya was taken to the district hospital, where he died during treatment. The police have arrested two accused.

Comply with revised prices of 137 anti-cancer drugs: NPPA

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) has warned of penal action against those failing to comply with the revised prices of 137 non-scheduled anti-cancer drugs. The NPPA has directed State drug controllers to strictly monitor the prices and submit their action taken reports by November 16, a release said on Friday. The new prices came into effect on November 9, after the government capped the trade margin on these 137 medicines at 30%. Complaints regarding overcharging or non-availability of medicines can be registered on the Pharma Sahi Daam app, the NPPA helpline (1800-111-255), or via email at monitoring-nppa@gov.in. PTI

Second-year student found dead at IIT-Roorkee hostel

A second-year BS-MS student at the Indian Institute of Technology, Roorkee was found dead in his hostel room on Thursday night, the police said. The deceased has been identified as Ayush Rajoria, 20, from Ghaziabad, who was pursuing a degree in mathematics and computing. Pradeep Bisht, SHO at the Roorkee police station, said that the IIT administration informed the police that the student had been experiencing depression and attending counselling sessions. The student's parents do not suspect foul play and have not filed a complaint, the police said. *(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416)*

Hope Pakistan will attend SCO meet in Delhi: Minister

Culture Minister says the two countries share a common civilisational legacy; however, External Affairs Ministry indicates it may not grant Punjab CM nod to travel to Lahore for another meet

Suhasini Haidar
Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

India and Pakistan have a shared "civilisational and cultural" past, Union Culture Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat said on Friday, adding that India hopes the neighbouring country will attend the upcoming SCO Civilisational Dialogue Forum in New Delhi. China, Kazakhstan, Iran, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan are among countries that have already confirmed their participation.

However, the government said it would follow "national policy" on Pakistan in view of the 2025 Pahalgam terror attacks, indicating that it may not grant Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann clearance to attend an international Punjabi cultural conference in Lahore in November-end.

Mr. Shekhawat was briefing presspersons about preparations for the first Civilisational Dialogue Forum of the 10-nation Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) grouping from November 20 to 22. As reported by *The Hindu* on October 28, the government has sent an invitation to Pakistan's Minister for National Heritage and Culture, Aurangzeb Khan Khichi, a first such ministerial-level invitation since 2023. Pakistan has not so far responded to the invitation, and while they have not confirmed the Minister's presence, sources said they expect some Pakistani official participation.



The SCO meet on November 21 and 22 will discuss civilisational and cultural expression, art and architecture, and language, literature and manuscripts, says Gajendra Singh Shekhawat. PTI

'Evolved together'

"I believe that Pakistan's civilisational and cultural progress is no different from ours [India's]," Mr. Shekhawat said in response to a question about the invitation, given the tensions between the two neighbours. "They [Pakistan] separated from us less than 100 years ago, but prior to that we [India and Pakistan] have evolved together. So, we should not have any differences over these issues."

The Minister said the purpose of the upcoming forum, first proposed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, was to see how the SCO could "go a step beyond geopolitical, strategic and bilateral relations and strengthen our cultural ties so that in the future we can have better relations and communications between the people of our countries".

Asked about Pakistan's participation on Friday, External Affairs Ministry official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said: "We look forward to hosting this civilisational dialogue." However, on the question of Mr. Mann, who has been invited along with Punjab MLAs by Pakistan's Minority Affairs Minister Ramesh Singh Arora to Lahore, Mr. Jaiswal took a tougher line.

Effect of attacks

"When it comes to relations with foreign countries, we have a national policy and expect everybody to abide by it," Mr. Jaiswal said, adding that the Ministry would make an assessment on the invitation from Pakistan in line with India's overall policy. "As far as our position on Pakistan after the Pahalgam terror attack is concerned, it should be amply clear to all as to where we stand," he said.

Outlining the programme for the SCO dialogue forum, Mr. Shekhawat said the discussions on November 21 and 22 will revolve around the broad themes of civilisational and cultural expression, art and architecture, and language, literature and manuscripts.

WHO flags funding gaps in prevention, treatment of TB

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

International donor funding fell by 14%, from $1.1 billion in 2024 to $0.94 billion in 2025, says report

Around 86% of the spending on measures against tuberculosis (TB) in 2025 came from domestic sources, the recently released Global Tuberculosis Report, 2026 by the World Health Organization (WHO) said, even as the reduction in international donor funding to combat the infectious disease remains a cause of concern.

The report notes that $22 billion is needed annually for TB prevention, diagnosis, treatment, and care to achieve the global targets agreed on at the 2023 United Nations high-level TB meeting by 2027.

In absolute terms, Brazil, China, India, the Russian Federation, and South Africa accounted for $3.7 billion (65%) of the total of $5.63 billion provided from domestic sources in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs).

Funding gap

The report notes that international donor funding fell by 14%, from $1.1 billion in 2024 to $0.94 billion in 2025, having been relatively stable at $1.1-1.3 billion a year between 2015 and 2024.

Financing for TB research and innovation, at $1.2 billion in 2023, continued to fall far short of the global target of $5 billion a year. Progress to date has been constrained by the overall level of investment, the report said .

"...Over 80% of cases and deaths are in low- and middle-income countries. In 2025, the largest number of new TB cases occurred in the WHO South-East Asia Region (35%)," the report said.

The WHO on Friday called upon countries in the Southeast Asia Region to accelerate action to end TB. The latest TB estimates show the region accounts for 3.6 million people who developed TB in 2025 – 34% of the global total – and 4,00,000 TB-related deaths, or 35% of the global total. "These numbers are a stark reminder that TB remains one of the Region's most pressing public health and development challenges," said Nilesh Buddha, officer in-charge, WHO South-East Asia Region.

'Deep-ocean submersible to undergo trial in early 2027'

Tiki Rajwi
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The 500-metre trial dive of India's deep-ocean submersible Matsya-6000 can be expected early next year, Srinivasa Kumar Tummala, Secretary, Ministry of Earth Sciences, has said. The trial dive will be a significant step towards India's push to send a crewed vehicle to a depth of 6,000 metres under the Samudrayaan Project.

"It is planned for a January-February time-frame in 2027. We are building Matsya-6000 in phases. So the first phase will be 500-metre depth trials," Mr. Tummala told *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the two-day 92nd Annual Meeting of the Indian Academy of Sciences (IASc), which opened at the National Centre for Earth Science Studies (NCESS) in Thiruvananthapuram on Friday.



Srinivasa Tummala. TIKI RAJWI

According to him, the Bay of Bengal will be the location for the dive. Two "pilots", or "aquanauts", from the National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT), the autonomous institute under the Ministry responsible for the project, are undergoing training.

Under India's Deep Ocean Mission, the Ministry had entrusted NIOT with the task of designing and developing the "deep-ocean human scientific submersible" – christened Matsya-6000 – as part of the Samudrayaan Project.

The submersible will be capable of transporting three humans within its compact 2.1-metre diameter spherical hull to 6,000 metres, giving India's ocean exploration capabilities a significant boost.

The NIOT is working closely with the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) for the construction of the titanium hull of Matsya-6000, the Secretary said.

"There are very few countries that are able to build a 2.1-metre (diameter) titanium sphere," he said.

Despite the challenges involved, Samudrayaan and Matsya-6000 have not garnered the kind of public appeal that the ISRO's own Gaganyaan programme has been enjoying. Yet, both initiatives share elements, the Secretary said.

Court orders narco test of TV actor in Ankita murder case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A special Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) court in Dehradun on Friday approved narco-analysis and polygraph tests for television actor Urmila Sanawar in connection with the 2022 murder of Ankita Bhandari.

Ms. Sanawar's lawyer, Shivani Tomar, told presspersons that her client had consented to both tests. She added that the tests would be conducted in Gujarat. A medical examination of Ms. Sanawar is likely to be conducted by the third week of November, following which the schedule for the tests will be confirmed.

Ms. Sanawar was arrested in Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh, on October 25, in connection with a separate case. A fresh FIR was registered against her in Dehradun a day later over alleged defamatory remarks against Sikkim Governor Dushyant Kumar Gautam and other BJP leaders. She was subsequently granted bail by a Haridwar court in a separate defamation and extortion case.



Urmila Sanawar

Ankita Bhandari, a receptionist at Vanantra Resort in the Pauri district of Uttarakhand, was murdered in September 2022 by resort owner Pulkit Arya, son of a former BJP leader, and his two aides. All three were convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment in 2025.

The case drew widespread attention amid allegations that Bhandari was killed after refusing to provide "special services" to a VIP expected to visit the resort that week. Her parents have alleged that Mr. Gautam was the VIP in question and that his political influence had prevented his name from being included in the investigation.

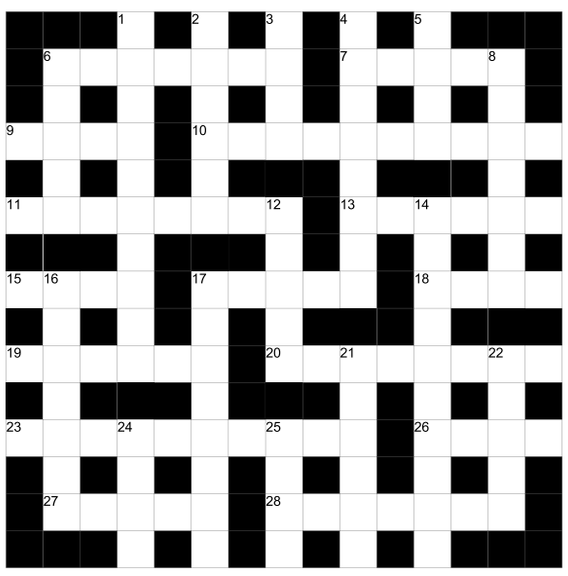
Ms. Sanawar has said she came to know about the alleged involvement of a politically influential VIP in the murder. The CBI had issued notices to her and former BJP MLA Suresh Rathore in connection with an audio recording referring to the alleged VIP link. Both had consented to undergo narco-analysis and polygraph tests in October. The case was handed over to the CBI in February.

TH CROSSWORD + 14948

(set by Gridzilla)

To solve this puzzle online, get across to our crossword site. *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



ACROSS

6. One may help in identifying Spooner's gentle horse (7)
7. Make use of a screen in the auditorium (5)
9. Trauma is caused by shock, mainly (4)
10. A place one barely enjoys? (6,4)
11. Frequently goes abroad, for nothing (5-3)
13. / 16D That Ola stopped moving (6,2,1,4)
15. For starters, it usually takes eons to withdraw case (4)
17. Grinder is good, after directions are switched (5)
18. Not the first to hang up? (4)
19. Way from podcaster's house (6)
20. Annoyed? No (6,2)
23. Gets ready for a shooting? (4,6)
26. Work quota doubles around lunchtime (4)
27. A prickly plant from south or north (5)
28. Take that drunkard in! (2,5)

DOWN

1. Caricature of senior MP is funny (10)
2. Catholic chaps reconcile immediately (2,4)
3. Old footage deceived cops (4)
4. Superintendent taking guards for a little nightly stress buster (8)
5. Secular man essentially hired by Indian insurance company (4)
6. A child shares no snack (5)
8. Daily in Paris, one avoids drink (2,5)
12. Extremely unusual silence surrounds labour camp (5)
14. Where a pedicurist should focus, being alert? (2,4,4)
16. See 13A
17. I'm prone casually after consuming heroin and another drug (8)
21. Least bothered about reading notifications? (6)
22. Friendly dogs love chilling (2,3)
24. Out to kill, for the most part (4)
25. Tongue, by itself, has no trace of pathology (4)

SUDOKU

	8					2		
3							5	1
	2		3	7	6			
4			6	9			7	2
				5				
8	6			1	2			5
			5	2	4		9	
2	5							6
		4					2	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

No. SS7060 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle

C	O	P	I	N	G		S	O	F	T	C	O	P	Y
	G		N		A		E		O		I		E	
C	R	E	D	I	T	O	R		R	E	V	E	R	E
	E		U		E		V		B		E		I	
			C	L	A	R	I	N	E	T	T	I	S	T
	H		T		U		C		A				H	
T	A	X	I				E	U	R	O	S	T	A	R
	R		V		T		I		S		T		B	
A	D	H	E	S	I	O	N				A	L	L	Y
	P				N		D		P		T		E	
H	A	U	T	E	C	O	U	T	U	R	E			
	L		A		T		S		T		W		A	
N	A	S	S	A	U		T	E	S	T	I	E	S	T
	T		T		R		R		C		D		I	
S	E	V	E	R	E	L	Y		H	E	E	H	A	W

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

7	6	9	1	2	3	5	8	4
8	1	4	5	9	6	3	7	2
3	2	5	8	7	4	1	6	9
1	8	2	3	4	7	9	5	6
9	4	7	6	5	1	8	2	3
5	3	6	9	8	2	7	4	1
6	7	3	4	1	8	2	9	5
2	9	1	7	6	5	4	3	8
4	5	8	2	3	9	6	1	7

FAITH

Chhath Puja

In Vedic cosmology, the powers of nature were venerated as energies that sustain life and grant wisdom and benediction. This signifies the relationship between nature and culture, said Prof. Kumool Abbi.

The festival of Chhath Puja, primarily dedicated to the Sun god, has a special significance in the States of Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, and countries such as Nepal.

Chhath Puja falls on the sixth day of Kartik Shukla Paksha in the Sashti Tithi as per the Hindu calendar. It is a festival observed for four days. Along with the Sun, the Goddess worshipped on this occasion is known as Chhathi Maiya, mentioned also as Usha, His divine consort, in the Vedas. The magnanimous Sun god and Chhathi Maiya are worshipped for prosperity, abundance, longevity, fertility, health, well-being, and the protection of children.

This festival reveres the Sun god in a spirit of thanksgiving and gratitude. It is also linked ecologically to the agricultural calendar, by seeking the divine to bequeath a good winter (kharif) harvest.

These rituals date back to the hoary hymns of the Rig Veda, worshipping the Sun as a source of illumination, knowledge, wisdom and sustenance.

Sun worship is also narrated in the *Ramayana*. The epic says Lord Rama and Sita together worshipped the Sun god. Sita observed a fast in the month of Kartik, during their coronation after returning to Ayodhya post the 14 years spent in exile. In the *Mahabharata*, Draupadi and the Pandavas performed the ritual of Chhath puja on the recommendation of the noble sage Daumya.

Brace for impact

High inflation due to external factors could soon exacerbate economic pain

India's much-hyped domestic economic resilience is set to be tested over the next few months as external factors start to impose inescapable pressures. A case in point is inflation. The latest data on retail inflation show that it crossed the Reserve Bank of India's 6% upper comfort limit in October 2026. According to economists, this is likely to continue through the third quarter of this financial year, which means at least two more months of high inflation. Agricultural shortfalls brought on by a patchy and deficient monsoon have meant that food inflation rose sharply to 8.5% in October 2026. Elevated fuel prices meant that inflation in the transport category also rose sharply. What is worse is that high inflation is spreading to almost every aspect of a household's day-to-day needs. In fact, the latest Consumer Price Index (CPI) data show that 10 of the 12 major categories saw inflation in October hitting their highest levels recorded in the new series of the index. So, things such as clothing, footwear, housing, furnishings, and services such as healthcare, education, communication, recreation, and restaurant and hospitality are not only getting more expensive, they are doing so at an accelerating rate. This would have been bad enough had wages been increasing in real terms. Yet, latest research by Data for India on the country's official wage statistics shows that, while nominal wages about doubled from 2012 to 2024, they actually fell 4% over the same period after adjusting for inflation. And this is sharper for high-skilled and high-earning workers. Lower wage earners saw marginal increases over this period. While this is of some comfort, it is the higher wage earners that drive consumption in an economy. Real wage contraction for them, which is likely to have worsened in 2026, will hit consumption levels and private investment.

Further, there is strong evidence to suggest that the official inflation metrics are not capturing the full extent of rising prices. Data on cash with the public and UPI transactions show the value of both have been growing in double digits over the last year and more, significantly outpacing nominal GDP growth. This either suggests that the informal economy is far larger than earlier thought or, more likely, that inflation is well above what the official figures are being able to capture. Unfortunately, there are no real magic-wand fixes to this situation. Inflation is largely beyond the government's control, and wage growth cannot happen overnight. The only way forward is to continue trying to spur sector-specific growth and warn people of the impending storm.

Critical ban

India needs to create an entire ecosystem for recycling of lithium-ion batteries

On November 10, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade banned the export of lithium-ion battery black mass by moving it from the "free" to the "prohibited" list of exports. Black mass is an intermediate product when spent batteries and factory scrap are shredded. It contains valuable lithium, nickel, cobalt, manganese and graphite. The Commerce Ministry says the ban will ensure feedstock for domestic refiners, lift their capacity utilisation and draw investment. While the recycling of lead-acid batteries end-to-end is an established ecosystem and formalised, too, lithium-ion battery recycling is an emerging segment with only a few dozen licensed operators but has much potential given the scale of use of such batteries in EVs. While the ban will redirect supply it will not automatically create a market and ecosystem. Just banning export without creating an entire ecosystem will only lead to dumping of lithium-ion batteries into landfills if the blackmass has no market. Blackmass production is a largely mechanical process but further downstream processing is more specialised chemical processing requiring larger investment and further policy support. If downstream units are online, their output can directly feed into indigenous lithium-ion battery manufacture.

India depends heavily on imports for critical minerals such as those used in battery inputs. Beyond working on supply aspects, the government must address the price gap to create a robust recycling market. Under the Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022, producers buy extended producer responsibility (EPR) certificates from recyclers but these are undervalued. Cheap certificates reward recycling on paper over investment in high-yield plants. A floor price that covers the full cost of recovery, with digital tracking, would fix that. Rare earths show how recycling remains a missed opportunity for India because of policy gaps. A smartphone can be up to 1% neodymium-iron-boron magnet by weight. That puts its rare earth content at about 3,000 parts per million, comparable to India's monazite beach sands. Extracting it takes less energy than mining. A magnet separated from the phone is about 30% rare earth. Magnets make up as much as 3% of a hard drive, but are usable only if they are removed before the drive is shredded for data destruction. Yet the e-waste rules do not require rare earth separation. Rare earths need a separate EPR category, too. Payment by weight cannot be applied for rare earth minerals.

To strengthen the Supreme Court, divide it



Pradeep S. Mehta

is the Secretary-General of CUTS International (Consumer Unity and Trust Society)



Vijay L. Kelkar

is the Vice President of the Pune International Centre

In 2016, three judges of the Supreme Court of India paused to ask a question about their own institution: had the apex court, established by the Constitution's framers to safeguard the Republic's foundational document, lost its way, drowning in ordinary appeals while its constitutional work withered? They framed 11 questions and referred it to a larger Bench. A decade later, the reference remains unheard. No emblem of the problem is sharper, nor any case for reform stronger: split the Supreme Court in two.

As 2025 drew to a close, the court carried 92,318 pending cases, its heaviest backlog ever and nearly 10,000 more than a year earlier. The caseload is growing at a pace that no reasonable enlargement of the Bench can outrun. The remedy is simple and not new: a lean Constitutional Court of about 11 judges in Delhi, hearing only constitutional cases and substantial questions of law, with four or five regional Courts of Appeal to handle the appeals that now flood the apex court. The idea is not to shrink the judiciary's reach but to sort its work, so that questions shaping the Republic are not decided in the same queue as those shaping a single case.

Consider how far the court has drifted. In the first half of the 1960s, its Constitution Benches decided an average of 134 cases a year; over the last decade, that has collapsed to fewer than 10. The docket, instead, has been swallowed by Special Leave Petitions, discretionary appeals under Article 136 that were intended to serve as a rare safety valve. By one count, they accounted for 84.6% of the court's admission docket in 2011. A tribunal designed to be the final word on the Constitution has turned itself into a general court of fourth appeal. It has admitted as much: in *Bihar Legal Support Society* (1986), a Constitution Bench under Chief Justice P.N. Bhagwati said it was never meant to be an ordinary court of appeal.

Beyond the backlog

The case for splitting the court is not merely that it is overcrowded. A two-tier structure would allow specialisation to achieve what an increase in judicial capacity alone cannot. A dedicated Constitutional Court, hearing a curated stream of cases, could sit in full Benches and deliver consistent, predictable rulings that settle questions once. Regional courts of appeal could specialise in the ordinary caseload and clear it far faster than an apex court. They would also bring the final tier of ordinary justice closer to the citizens who need it. Every large legal system has converged on this pyramid-shaped structure: a final court works best when it decides a few cases carefully, while the tiers below it handle many more quickly.

> Adding judges without sorting the work risks enlarging the same overburdened court. The task is not to move the same work faster, but to sort it

The 229th Law Commission Report (2009) laid out a full blueprint for a Constitution Bench in Delhi with four regional Cassation Benches. In 2023, a Parliamentary Standing Committee recommended regional Benches, which the Union Law Ministry has since accepted. The model is well tested in the very democracies India is compared to.

The U.S. Supreme Court sits atop 13 federal Courts of Appeals, deciding only a sliver of cases. South Africa runs a two-court system: a Constitutional Court in Johannesburg, and a separate Supreme Court of Appeal in Bloemfontein for everything else. Germany's Federal Constitutional Court in Karlsruhe hears constitutional matters alone, while specialised federal courts handle other areas of law.

And this is not only a matter of systems built that way from the start: countries have made the very change India now contemplates. Brazil is the closest recent parallel. Its Supreme Federal Tribunal once carried the same double burden as ours, guarding the Constitution while drowning in ordinary federal appeals. The 1988 Constitution created a separate Superior Tribunal of Justice to take over that appellate load.

Brazil, however, also offers a warning: the split alone did not ease the backlog, which declined only after the apex court was given the power to filter out cases it did not need to hear. The tool is familiar from the very courts India admires. The U.S. Supreme Court grants review to roughly one per cent of the 7,000 petitions it receives each year, a discretion held since 1925; Brazil's apex court, after a 2004 reform, hears a constitutional appeal only where the question carries a "general repercussion" beyond the parties. Without such a filter, a Constitutional Court would inherit, in miniature, the very congestion it was built to escape. And the route need not be treacherous: the 229th Report argued Article 130 may permit regional Benches without a constitutional amendment, meaning the first steps could be taken by the court itself, without waiting for Parliamentary approval.

The strongest objection must be stated at full strength, because it is why this reform has stalled for so long, and because it is held by those who know the institution best. The concern, voiced by successive Chief Justices, is that a divided Supreme Court may no longer be a single supreme one: separate the constitutional work from the appellate work, and the regional courts could come to be seen as lesser venues, with litigants pressing to reach the apex court in Delhi, until the authority that flows from having one final court is diffused. There is real force in this. An apex court's power lies partly in its indivisibility: it is the last word, with no higher forum to appeal to and no rival court to be played against it.

Restoring the court

But the concern mistakes the disease for the cure. A single court is only a single voice when it can speak with one, and ours cannot: it already sits in a dozen small Benches that often contradict each other, its constitutional work reduced to a handful of Constitution Benches a year.

The indivisibility being defended is a fiction; the court is already divided, not by design but by sheer volume, into scattered panels whose rulings no one can fully reconcile. Separation would rescue the constitutional core of one that has fractured on its own. When the Bench was expanded to 34 in 2019, pendency stood near 60,000; today it is close to 93,000. In 2025, the court disposed of 65,615 cases and still fell behind, as 75,410 fresh matters arrived. In 2026, Parliament raised the sanctioned strength again, to 38. Adding judges without sorting the work risks enlarging the same overburdened court. The task is not to move the same work faster, but to sort it.

The Supreme Court that gave us the basic structure doctrine, and once stood as the boldest constitutional court in the democratic world, now rarely sits in constitutional judgment at all. No outside hand has diminished it; it has been buried under its own docket. To leave it as it is, out of reverence for a unity that no longer exists, is to mistake sentiment for strength. Splitting the court would let it return to its pristine structure, while a new tier of regional appeals courts would finally give ordinary litigants the swift justice they are owed. That would not be its diminishment, but its restoration.

(With contributions from Anushka Kewlani of CUTS)

The challenge of holding the Quad together



Harsh V. Pant

is Vice-President, Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi



Sayantan Haldar

is Associate Fellow, Maritime Studies, Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi

Speaking to the media on the sidelines of the G20 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Atlanta, the U.S. Secretary of State announced that the leaders of the four Quad countries – India, Australia, Japan and the U.S. – are expected to meet in Manila in November, on the sidelines of the ASEAN Summit. The announcement is significant as this would be the first summit-level meeting of the Quad leaders since Donald Trump began his second term as U.S. President. It would also be the first such summit attended by Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi since she assumed office. The last Quad Leaders' Summit was held in Wilmington in 2024, when Joe Biden was U.S. President and Fumio Kishida was Japan's Prime Minister.

While India was expected to host the subsequent Quad Leaders' Summit, the grouping underwent a period of intense strategic turbulence in 2025, on account of Washington's shifting geopolitical priorities and changing political dynamics in its bilateral relations with Quad members, especially India. However, this did not result in complete collapse of the grouping. Apart from the leader-level summit, the group has remained successful in continuing its operational synergies in its various initiatives. This was most evident in the elevation of the Quad's Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness initiative to the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration framework, launched in New Delhi in May 2026, following the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting.

Keeping the Quad afloat

Additionally, the foreign ministers of the four Quad countries held multiple meetings across 2025 and 2026, a period characterised as the nadir of the group's political alignment. In 2025, the foreign ministers met twice in Washington, with the first meeting marking Marco Rubio's first engagement as U.S. Secretary of State. In 2026, they met three times, in New Delhi, Manila, and Atlanta. A natural priority area for the agenda of these meetings was to schedule a leader-level summit for the group. For a grouping of this nature, which has neither a permanent bureaucracy nor an institutional framework of its own, such summits serve as crucial platforms to reaffirm its shared purpose and chart its agenda for the months ahead.

> The big ticket question confronting the Quad, however, is how Donald Trump engages with the group and the broader Indo-Pacific geography

The big ticket question confronting the Quad, however, is how President Trump engages with the group and the broader Indo-Pacific geography. This, in many ways, is going to be the first occasion where Mr. Trump could articulate his vision and outlook towards the region for the remainder of this term. It was during his first tenure in the White House that the Quad was revived in 2017, and the Quad bolstered its approach towards the Indo-Pacific by renaming the U.S. Pacific Command to U.S. Indo-Pacific Command. However, since beginning his second term, Mr. Trump's priorities have been dictated by the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war, Washington's approach towards the transatlantic relationship and NATO, and the war in West Asia. Although the U.S. has not publicly expressed disinterest in the Indo-Pacific, regional partners have remained cautious about the possibility of a fundamental shift in Washington's engagement with the region.

President Trump's insistence that the U.S. expects its partners to enhance burden-sharing within the transatlantic security architecture it is invested in has also caused concern in the Indo-Pacific. The U.S. continues to remain a significant security actor in the region, especially in the Pacific, with several like-minded countries embedded in the U.S.-led security architecture. Furthermore, the White House's decision to review AUKUS has heightened concern and uncertainty among other players in the Indo-Pacific. This has prompted various countries to undertake measures to diversify their security policies. For example, Japan, through its One Cooperative Effort Among Nations (OCEAN) framework, has sought to increasingly reshape its post-war security posture by deepening strategic alignment with partner countries. Australia has made efforts to strengthen defence partnerships with India, Japan, Southeast Asian countries, and Pacific Island countries to deter China's growing footprint in the region. India continues to pursue a policy of multi-alignment and diversification of defence and strategic ties with like-minded countries in the Indian Ocean and the wider Indo-Pacific.

The recent meeting between the Defence Ministers of JAI (Japan-Australia-India) in Cebu also signals a willingness among these countries to further deepen their partnership notwithstanding the nature and character of Washington's role in the region. New entrants in the Indo-Pacific strategic landscape, such as France, have also sought to bolster ties with regional countries to sustain a balanced security environment in the region. Even though Mr. Trump's actions have spurred a rethink on the changing security order in the Indo-Pacific among regional partners, Washington's role remains critical, especially in the face of a worsening maritime security environment prompted by continued expansion of China's footprint. Washington's role in safeguarding the Taiwan Strait, a critical flashpoint in the Indo-Pacific strategic geography, remains significant.

A strategic message from Manila

While questions remain about the nature and character of U.S. involvement in the Indo-Pacific, at least for the remainder of President Trump's tenure in White House, the announcement of the imminent leader-level summit of the Quad appears to have breathed new life into the group. Even though India was expected to host the next leader-level summit following the previous meeting in Wilmington in 2024, the Philippines' hosting of the summit also reinforces one of the group's foundational strategic pillars – ASEAN centrality. Arguably, the Philippines remains at the front and centre of Chinese misadventures in the Indo-Pacific, with ongoing tussles over sovereignty issues between Manila and Beijing.

Following the Quad's track record at previous leader-level summits, its leaders are expected to reiterate the importance of respecting sovereignty in the South and East China Seas and condemn attempts by powers to disregard international law in the region. Delivering such a message from Manila would carry the weight of strategic symbolism. For Mr. Trump, the objectives of this Indo-Pacific visit should be dictated by two priorities: resetting American posture in the region and helping assert the Quad's commitment against Chinese belligerence from Manila.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Safeguarding voting rights

Universal adult franchise is the bedrock of Indian democracy, yet hasty digitisation risks turning software into an instrument of exclusion. Whether imposing arbitrary deadlines in Delhi or leaving over half a crore voters "under adjudication" in West Bengal, disregarding technological readiness risks undermining citizens' fundamental voting rights. Electoral governance demands methodical testing, not rushed rollouts.

Vinay Sivakumar
Hyderabad

Burden of inflation

Untamed inflation is a grave concern for the wage-earning class. For more than a decade, the wages for a major section have not been revised upward, forcing them to keep tightening their belts further. In a number of States, wage boards have either not been formed or are not functioning. Normally, government figures fail to reflect the actual reality on the ground. Now, even the official figures show rising inflation. Appropriate government intervention is inevitable to stabilise prices and rescue wage earners from serious plight.

A.G. Rajmohan
Andhra Pradesh

Restoring stability

The recent killings of security personnel and attacks on security installations underline the disturbing reality that militancy continues to raise its ugly head in J&K. Despite sustained counter-terrorism operations and claims of improved security, militant groups retain the ability to strike and disrupt normalcy. The government cannot afford complacency or treat isolated successes as evidence of lasting peace. Alongside firm security measures, winning public confidence and dismantling militant support networks remain essential to restoring stability in the region.

Gregory Fernandes
Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

When boys' voices break

Child sexual abuse of boys often goes unreported as fear, shame, and social stigma keep children and their families silent. **Abhinay Deshpande** reports from Telangana on how families struggle to help their children recover and seek justice, which is often delayed

Trigger warning: The following article talks about child sexual abuse.
Disclaimer: The Hindu did not interview the children subjected to sexual abuse to avoid causing further distress or making them relive their experiences. Their parents were interviewed separately.

On September 23, Hrishkesh*, a 15-year-old, was on his way to tuition class after school, when a person who lived in the same locality stopped him a few metres from his house in Hyderabad. The person asked him to come into the house to help with something. When he refused, he was allegedly dragged inside and locked in. A dog was then let loose to prevent him from escaping.

What happened inside was something the boy would initially struggle to describe to his father. "The person threatened him, removed his clothes and sexually assaulted him. My son is well-built and around 5.5 feet tall. But he was so frightened by the threats that he could not fight back," says his father, who works in a privately run company.



Hrishkesh eventually managed to escape and reach his tuition centre. From there, he called his father, Mohan*, crying, and asked if he could return home.

"I could make out from his voice that something was terribly wrong. I rushed home, but he wouldn't tell me anything. He took a shower and sat quietly. I kept asking him what had happened, but he wouldn't respond," Mohan recalls.

Mohan, a single parent, was worried by his son's silence. When repeated attempts to get him to speak failed, he called Hrishkesh's aunt, hoping the boy would be more comfortable talking to her.

"I thought perhaps he was finding it difficult to tell me something, so I asked my sister to speak to him. When she told me that my son had been sexually assaulted, I was shocked. We had never heard of something like this happening to a boy, especially a 15-year-old," he says, struggling to hold back his emotions.

Mohan was shaken, but he knew he could not let his son see this. The boy, he says, kept repeating that something "bad" had happened to him. "He also told us that the person had tried to influence him by saying he would pass Class 10 with flying colours because he had their blessings," Mohan says, of the trans woman, who had allegedly assaulted his son.

Once Hrishkesh had calmed down, Mohan asked whether he wanted to go to the police. "I didn't want to force him into anything. I asked if he was ready to tell the police what had happened, and he agreed. I was relieved that he had the courage to speak up. We also felt that unless we reported it, another boy in the locality could become a victim," he says.

> Sexual abuse of boys may remain undisclosed because of shame, fear of ridicule, concerns about masculinity, family reputation and reluctance to acknowledge that boys can also be victims of sexual violence
>
> **CHARU SINHA**
> Director General of Police (WSW), Telangana

Data shared by the Women Safety Wing (WSW) of the Telangana Police show that 127 boys were recorded as victims under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, between January 2024 and September 2026 in the State.

The number rose from four in 2024 to 61 in 2025. In the first nine months of 2026 alone, 62 boys were recorded as victims. Hrishkesh was one of them.

The rise in recorded cases does not necessarily mean that more boys are being sexually assaulted. It could also mean that more children and their families are willing to report abuse.

Across Telangana, and elsewhere in the country, child sexual abuse of boys often remains hidden. Some families are reluctant to report such incidents because of shame, the fear of how society would react, and a concern for their child's reputation. Some boys are threatened into silence, while others are too frightened to tell their parents. Younger children may not even understand what has happened to them. Mohan and his son are outliers.

Known devil

A study published in 2017 in the *Indian Journal of Psychiatry*, titled 'Silence of male child sexual abuse in India: Qualitative analysis of barriers for seeking psychiatric help in a multidisciplinary unit in a general hospital,' identified "patriarchy" as one of the barriers preventing boys from seeking psychiatric help after sexual abuse.

The study argues that protecting children requires equal attention to boys and girls. "Patriarchy is not protecting our boys more than our girls in childhood. The very low rates of reporting and help-seeking among victims of sexually abused boys in India could be due to the hegemony of patriarchy," the study authors say.

These Telangana numbers, for instance, account only for cases that reached the authorities. Police officers and those working with children in distress say it is difficult to estimate how many boys are sexually abused but never report it, particularly when the perpetrator is someone the child knows.

"In most cases, the perpetrators are known to the children. They either threaten or lure them into remaining silent about the abuse, allowing the perpetrator to escape punishment or continue the abuse until they speak up," says Dr. P. Lavanya Naik Jadav, DCP (She Team and Bharosa), Hyderabad.

In Telangana's capital, She Teams have been set up by the police to provide security to women. Bharosa is a Support Centre for Women and Children.

In one case last year, a child with an intellectual disability was repeatedly sexually assaulted by the warden of a state-run juvenile rescue home in Hyderabad, say police. When the child finally spoke about the assault, five other boys came forward with similar allegations, the officer says, declining to share further details.

In another case reported in August, Mohammed Irfan*, 13, a child from Hyderabad's Old City, was allegedly sexually assaulted by Asif*, 23, at the latter's house. Imran*, Irfan's father and a single parent who works as an electrician, recalls how his son gradually lost interest in studies and food, becaming physically weak. He was hospitalised for several days, but even then, he did not tell his family what had happened.

"He was terrified. Initially, we did not know what to do. But things have slowly started getting better for him," he says. "My son and Asif used to play cricket together in the locality. He only told his older brother about the assault. It had been going on for some months and Asif had threatened him so he would not tell anyone," says Imran.

Telangana police data show that in 61.8% of the recorded cases, the accused were known to the child. They included relatives, neighbours, teachers, schoolmates, and acquaintances. Strangers accounted for 38%.

Under-reporting for a reason

Cases are not confined to Hyderabad. In 2025, while the city recorded 28 male child victims, Khammam district, almost 200 kilometres from Hyderabad, recorded 13. Between January and September 2026, Hyderabad recorded 29 victims, followed by Mahabubabad district, with nine. Warangal, Nirmal, and Karimnagar recorded three each, while Suryapet, Rajanna-Sircilla, Narayanpet, Medak, and Mancherial districts reported two each.

In Khammam district, a case involving students at a residential school shows how difficult it can be to get children and their families to speak, even after the abuse has been reported.

In February 2025, a boy was struggling to concentrate on his studies and was reluctant to return to the hostel of a government residential school. When his parents asked him why, he disclosed that the warden had been abusing him. Gradually, other boys also came forward with their accounts. It came to light that more than 15 students, all between 12 and 15 years, had been abused on multiple occasions.

But when the case was registered, only six boys came forward to record their statements, says G. Rajakumari, a counsellor at the Bharosa Centre in Khammam.

She says several boys and their families were unwilling to testify because they feared shame and humiliation from society. Even after the allegations came to light, some families did not want to pursue the case.

According to the Director General of Police (WSW) Charu Sinha, boys accounted for only 1.37% of the total child victims recorded over the three reporting years. "Such an exceptionally low proportion of reported male victims warrants closer examination of potential under-reporting," she says. Sinha says the gap raises questions about how many boys are suffering abuse without telling anyone.

"Although this disparity cannot establish the actual magnitude of under-reporting, it warrants closer examination. Sexual abuse of boys may remain undisclosed because of shame, fear of ridicule, concerns about masculinity, family reputation and reluctance to acknowledge that boys can also be victims of sexual violence," she explains.

Boys are often expected to be strong, independent, and capable of protecting themselves. Such expectations, she says, can make it harder for them to seek out help to say they have been abused. "This underlines the importance of protection and awareness, especially within familiar environments," Sinha says.

Delayed disclosure, fear of stigma, reluctance among families to report incidents and difficulties in obtaining clear accounts from traumatised children remain major challenges for investigators, she adds.

The slow system of justice

When families approach the police, getting justice can take years. At present, 1,769 POCSO cases are pending before two designated courts in Hyderabad city alone. Public Prosecutor Alluri Ram Reddy says each court has one judge and one Public Prosecutor handling nearly 900 pending cases at a time, on average. Each trial requires at least two to three hours.

"If a court functions from 9.30 a.m. to 5 p.m., nearly half the day is spent hearing other petitions, including bail applications. In the remaining time, judges can take up only one or two POCSO cases a day. Is it humanly possible for a judge and a PP to handle 900 cases?" Reddy asks.

He says the government needs to establish more courts to deal with the pending cases.

"The government must provide the necessary infrastructure in proportion to the pendency of cases to ensure speedy trials," he says.

Another Public Prosecutor says delays in trials often mean that children have to live with the trauma of sexual assault for years along with revisiting unresolved cases repeatedly. "It is unfair on the part of the system to make a child, whether a girl or a boy, repeatedly recall such a horrific experience. Every time they are made to revisit the incident, it causes further trauma. Making laws alone is not enough. The government must also ensure their implementation by providing sufficient resources," the prosecutor says, adding that Hyderabad needs at least four courts to speed up trials.

For some survivors, the effects of sexual abuse can continue long after childhood.

Child psychiatrist Dr. M. Gowri Devi of Asha Hospital, Hyderabad, says there are many myths surrounding child sexual abuse. One is that a child's sexual orientation may change after the abuse. "This is untrue," she says, reiterating that sexual orientation is not triggered by trauma.

Awareness for vigilance

Police say awareness campaigns are particularly needed in residential schools and religious educational institutions, where they say a majority of the reported cases are coming from.

Dr. Devi says women, too, sexually abuse boys, but such incidents are often not reported or recognised as abuse. She recalls three cases involving boys who were sexually assaulted by women, including their own mother, a mother's close friend, and a tuition teacher.

In some cases, she says, teenage boys may mistake the abuse for affection or pleasure without understanding that they are being sexually exploited. The belief that boys cannot be sexually assaulted by women can also prevent victims from speaking about their experiences.

This is why child sex abuse educators talk in terms of safe touch and unsafe touch, rather than good touch and bad touch, because what may feel good may not be safe.

"While some may not recognise the abuse during childhood, its psychological impact can surface years later, particularly when people enter relationships or get married. Some may struggle with intimacy, trust, and their relationship with their spouse, without initially understanding that these difficulties could be linked to the abuse they experienced as children," Dr. Devi says.

A 2022 study, titled 'Disclosure of child sexual abuse: Experiences of men survivors in India,' published in *The British Journal of Social Work*, finds that disclosing child sexual abuse can be a lifelong process for male survivors.

In their conclusion, the study authors say, "When survivors disclose, responses of disclosure recipients are not always supportive or affirming. Unhelpful responses include victim blaming and silence. Barriers as well as unhelpful responses to disclosure are often linked to patriarchal constructions of masculinity and heteronormativity in society."

Dr. Devi says one of the first things she tries to do when treating children who have experienced sexual abuse is to help them understand that they are not responsible for what happened.

"I often ask them to imagine walking on a pavement when a vehicle suddenly hits them. Whose fault is it? The driver's, isn't it? I tell them to look at the assault in the same way. It was not their fault, and they should not blame themselves for what happened," she explains.

She says the trauma can be just as severe for boys as for girls, though boys often take longer to talk about it. Recovery, too, can take years. "A lot depends on the children's self-confidence, willingness to seek help, treatment and, above all, support from their family," she says.

**Names and other identifiable details have been changed to protect identity*

deshpande.abhinay@thehindu.co.in



A church in Purba Medinipur, West Bengal, which was attacked by a mob. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Choosing faith over fear

West Bengal has witnessed a sudden, rapid spike in attacks on Christian home fellowships and churches since the summer of 2026, when the BJP government came to power in the State. **Senjuti Sengupta** and **Shiv Sahay Singh** report on the fear of the community that is less than 1% of the population in West Bengal

A 65-year-old woman, Purnima (name changed to protect privacy), had eagerly waited for October 31, 2026, when a new church was to be inaugurated in front of her house. Her family had donated a significant amount of land and the freshly painted white building of William Cary Memorial Church was ready to welcome devotees at Narayantala village in Basanti block of West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district. Now, she shudders when she thinks about what happened on that Saturday afternoon to the church.

"The gate of the church was opened for the first and the last time on October 31. During the inaugural function, a group entered the premises and attacked the priests and others who were participating in the ceremony," Purnima says, recalling the attack that left her and several others injured. She says she was hit with a stick and had to be hospitalised for a day. After the attack, the church has been closed, but Purnima says she often goes to its door to peek at the picture of Jesus Christ through a broken window.

Narayantala village houses about 300 families, most of whom are Christian. There is a church in the village, which the locals claim is about 200 years old. Due to some disagreements between the members of the old church about two years ago, seven of the families, including that of Purnima, decided to establish a separate church. Most of the villagers who witnessed the attack say the mob raised slogans of "Jai Shri Ram" and comprised largely of people not from the village. The officials at the Basanti police station say *prima facie*, the matter involved a dispute between two churches located within 100 metres of each other in the same locality.

The mob attacked one of the priests at the church with rods and bricks, says Samiran Mondal. The priest recalls that after attacking the church, the mob attacked some Christian families and beat them, including the women. They also asked the women to remove the traditional *sakha* (white bangles) and *sindoor* (vermillion), both symbols of married Hindu women.

Christians have been at the receiving end of faith-based violence between May and November 2026. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government came into power in May this year.

Herod Mullick, founder-secretary of the Bangiya Christiya Pariseba (BCP, Bengal Christian Council), an interdenominational forum representing Christians in West Bengal, says his organisation has recorded 48 such incidents, out of which seven belong to mainline denominations, while the rest are independent congregations.

The districts of South 24 Parganas, North 24 Parganas, Purba Medinipur, and Paschim Medinipur have registered the highest number of attacks, he says.

So far, no group has claimed responsibility for the attacks. West Bengal Minister of Minority Affairs Kshudiram Tudu says he has not heard anything from Christian representatives, while Ajay Mukund Ranade, Additional Director General (Law and Order), West Bengal Police, says there is no compiled data on attacks against Christians. Mullick says only 16 FIRs have been registered so far.

'Forced to perform rituals'

Amid attacks, scores of survivors of faith-based violence participated in the People's Tribunal on Christian Persecution in central Kolkata, held at Kolkata's Muslim Institute opposite the Lord Jesus Church on November 2. Those who spoke before the tribunal said they were living in fear and could no longer hold prayer gatherings at home. The tribunal was organised by three organisations: Karwan-e-Mohabbat, Sabar Institute, and Aamra Ek Sachetan Prayas.

The jury at the people's tribunal comprised former Chief Information Commissioner of India Wajahat Habibullah, former bureaucrat and former MP Jawhar Sircar, journalist John Dayal, and activists Aakar Patel, Vidya Dinkar, and Harsh Mander, among others.

> After we redecorated the church and started prayers, the second attack took place on September 7, which left seven church members injured. The mob broke CCTV cameras, damaged fans, bulbs. They did not even spare religious symbols, including the holy cross
>
> **DIGBIJOY MANNA**
> Head of Trinity of Joy church, Brajanath Chak village, Purba Medinipur

Ankita Mahalanobis, who works with *Alt News*, an independent fact-checking initiative, presented her analysis before the people's tribunal. She said between July 1 and September 30, she analysed 35 incidents. In the majority of them, the perpetrators had uploaded the videos on social media, with claims of allegiance to Hindutva groups, she said.

While Habibullah said the attacks posed a great deal of harm to Bengal's spiritual tradition, Mander asked how it took just four months after the BJP came to power to "brutalise society in the State and instil fear among a section of people". Patel also highlighted the timing of these events and said Bengalis should not think that they are less vulnerable than people in other parts of the country.

A woman from Keshpur in Paschim Medinipur district shared an incident before the gathering. The woman narrated that on October 2, Gandhi Jayanti, her house was attacked by a mob of 80 to 100 people while a prayer meeting was being held. The woman said she had been disrobed and beaten up by a few people from the mob, which also included a few women.

"Those who attacked me asked why I should wear *sankha* and *sindoor*. I told them wearing these was part of my Bengali identity, not my religious identity, but they did not listen and assaulted and humiliated me," she says. Several women who have been attacked have alleged that they have been forced to perform Hindu rituals.

An FIR lodged by a woman at the Chandrakona police station in Paschim Medinipur district on October 20. The complainant alleged that on October 18, a mob tried to coerce her and her family members into performing Hindu rituals. One person, named in the FIR, threatened to rape and kill her if they did not renounce their faith. "They then forcibly bathed me in front of everyone as part of a so-called purification ritual. My clothes were removed without my consent and I was made to take part in that ritual against my will," the woman wrote in the police complaint. The woman also alleged that the accused forced them to visit a Durga Puja pandal in a village nearby and forced them to perform Hindu rituals.

Mullick has been among those repeatedly raising the issue of recurrent attacks on Christians. Until a decade ago, he was campaigning for the rights of minority educational institutions, has taken up the responsibility of documenting such attacks, registering police complaints, and providing legal aid to the survivors. "I can say this with certainty: these are not isolated incidents, but planned attacks where prayer meetings are being targeted," he says.

He points out that West Bengal has a minuscule Christian community: 0.72%, as per the Census 2011. Mullick says despite the violence raging on for months, he still cannot understand why Christians are being targeted in West Bengal. "Christians are not considered a vote bank of any party, and there was no mention of the community during the high-pitched election campaign," he points out. He accuses the police of going soft on those who are behind the attacks.

ADG Ranade says, "There is no compiled data on how many people have been arrested (for such attacks). However, the necessary action is being taken by the local police where FIRs have been lodged."

Claims of recurrent attacks

The survivors of faith-based violence across the districts of West Bengal have claimed recurrent threats and multiple attacks. Only a few days after the newly inaugurated church was attacked in Basanti, a group of locals took out a procession and burnt the effigies of the church priests.

The gathering, on November 5 at Basanti, alarmed the Christian community. It was organised by Adivasi Eikya Parishad, a local organisation, whose representatives said Adivasis are being lured for conversion on the promise of curing disease, which should not be allowed.

Digbijoy Manna, head of Trinity of Joy Church in Purba Medinipur's Brajanath Chak village, claims his church was attacked twice on May 4 and September 7. Manna says when the first attack took place, there was no one at the church. "After we redecorated the church and started prayers, the second attack took place on September 7, which left seven church members injured. The mob broke CCTV cameras, damaged fans, bulbs. They did not even spare religious symbols, including the holy cross," the priest says. According to him, after the attack, church members have stopped visiting the church. Prayer meetings are now held online.

Mamata Joshua, from Asansol in Paschim Bardhaman, says she and other members of the community are living in fear after their prayer gathering was attacked twice on May 31 and August 7. "We had even approached the local BJP MLA, who had given us permission to continue prayers, but then there was a second attack. We are living under constant fear," she says.

Priests targeted

Anup Kumar Ghosh, a priest at Apostolic Reformation Church in Midnapore town, was arrested by the police after a mob attacked his church on July 3, when he was holding a feast after a marriage ceremony.

"I was booked under several sections, including charges of attempted murder, on the basis of a complaint lodged by those who attacked the church. Though I am out on bail after spending 41 days behind bars, I have to present myself at the police station every week," the priest says. He adds he cannot stay in the area where his church is located and is living 16 kilometres away, for safety.

At Ajaya village in Khejuri-I block of Purba Medinipur district, Swapan Kumar Barui was first threatened over the telephone and then attacked. The call threatening him with dire consequences came on July 22, and he was attacked the very next morning.

"They threatened me, telling me to convert to Hinduism. When I refused, they ostracised us. For the last five months, no one has either visited us or spoken to us. They also stopped our relatives from visiting our house," the priest says. The locals who attacked him allegedly said officials would be asked to remove their names from government schemes. Barui says he and his family had converted to Christianity in 2017.

Reverend Arpan Rana, West Bengal's general secretary of the National Christian Council, a human rights network promoting communal harmony, sees a pattern in the attacks. He says the majority of targets over the past few months have been home fellowships or prayer meetings held at home, mostly run by women.

Rana refers to a little-known law: The West Bengal Religious Buildings And Places Act, 1985, which imposes restrictions and conditions on holding religious prayers in public and private buildings not designated as religious places. Permission is to be granted by the administration for holding such prayer meetings. According to him, police are using the law not to register an FIR in cases of mob attacks, but sometimes booking those who are holding such prayer meetings. He calls all the attacks a precursor to something major like an anti-conversion law.

Remaining non-committal

Christian groups like the BCP organised a march in Kolkata on November 5 to highlight the attacks. Hundreds of people participated in the rally that brought together Christian organisations.

Mullick, the founder-secretary of BCP, claims that repeated appeals to Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari to uncover the truth remain unheeded, while miscreants who take the law into their own hands operate with complete impunity.

Recently, a five-member delegation of Christian leaders met senior Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) leader of West Bengal Dr. Jishnu Basu and raised the issue of recent mob attacks on congregations and churches.

Basu, who is the South Bengal Saha Khetra Prachar Pramukh, a regional public relations officer, responds that dialogue will continue with the representatives of Christian organisations, but there are genuine concerns about forced conversions. The RSS leader says there should be investigations both into the attacks and the allegations of forced conversion.

When asked about attacks on churches and Christian religious gatherings, MP Tudu says, "Some reports have been circulated on various media platforms. We could not verify them. But I have received no report from any individual from the Christian community."

With Christmas just a few weeks away, there are apprehensions among the Christian community, since this will be the first Christmas under the BJP regime in West Bengal. Reverend Rana says the Chief Minister, while responding to questions about a proposed mosque in Murshidabad, had stated that setting up temples, mosques, churches, and gurdwaras are matters of constitutional rights.

"We appreciate this positive expression, particularly the Chief Minister's recognition of churches alongside other places of worship. But the BJP government must ensure that its election slogan of *Bhoy* out, *bhorsa* in (Fear out, Faith in) be ensured in letter and in spirit," he says.

senjuti.sengupta@thehindu.co.in
shivsahay.s@thehindu.co.in



Digbijoy Manna and a fellow church-goer standing near the entrance of Trinity of Joy Church in Brajanath Chak, which was allegedly damaged by a group of miscreants who also vandalised the interiors. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Vemula Srinivasulu, Officer on Special Duty (CMRF) to Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy, reviews files related to financial assistance under the Chief Minister's Relief Fund at the State Secretariat, in Hyderabad on Thursday. NAGARA GOPAL

Softening the blow of medical costs

Medical treatment can come at a crippling cost, particularly for families with limited means. But the Chief Minister's Relief Fund has emerged as a source of support for patients across Telangana, helping them access treatment without having to shoulder the entire financial burden. **Abhinay Deshpande** examines the reach of the fund and the scale of assistance disbursed to those in need

Just when Kokkala Abhinay's family thought the worst was behind them, the cancer returned.

On October 21, the seven-year-old from Yadadri-Bhuvanagiri district was rushed to the Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences (NIMS), Hyderabad, after being diagnosed with B-cell acute lymphoblastic leukaemia (B-ALL), a fast-growing form of blood cancer, for the second time.

For nearly a year, Abhinay had been leading a normal life after doctors declared the cancer in remission. His parents had begun to put the difficult months of treatment behind them, but the relief was short-lived. "He is going through the same painful treatment all over again," says his father, Prakash, who works at a two-wheeler showroom in the district.

Abhinay first fell ill in November 2024. He had a persistent fever and complained of stomach pain. His parents initially gave him over-the-counter medicines. But when the fever stayed for weeks, he was taken for blood tests. The results prompted doctors to refer the boy to a private children's hospital in Hyderabad, where further tests confirmed B-ALL.

The diagnosis left Prakash in shock. His showroom earnings were barely enough to meet household expenses, let alone the cost of treatment. Abhinay was initially treated at the private hospital before being shifted to NIMS. Prakash had spent more than ₹2 lakh by then, of which ₹60,000 was reimbursed through the Chief Minister's Relief Fund (CMRF). At NIMS, the family received a Letter of Credit (LoC) worth ₹2.50 lakh, which helped meet treatment costs. Abhinay was eventually discharged.

With the cancer returning, the family is back at NIMS, once again facing the uncertainty of prolonged treatment. A second LoC worth ₹2.50 lakh has been issued.

Abhinay is among lakhs of patients across Telangana whose families have turned to the CMRF for help with medical expenses they cannot afford.

A lifeline for many families

As per official data, the State government has provided ₹1,780 crore to more than 5.10 lakh beneficiaries under the CMRF. A further ₹890 crore was disbursed through 42,890 LoCs for hospital treatment, taking the total assistance to ₹2,670 crore.

Of the ₹890 crore disbursed through LoCs, more than ₹830 crore, accounting for over 93%, went to NIMS.

MNJ Institute of Oncology and Regional Cancer Centre received over ₹22 crore for 630 cases while the Government ENT Hospital in Koti received over ₹19 crore for 340 cases. The Basavatarakam Indo-American Cancer Hospital, run by a trust, received ₹7.5 crore for 189 cases, says Vemula Srinivasulu, Officer on Special Duty (CMRF) to Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy.

> Just like the National Disaster Response Fund is meant to support natural or man-made disasters, the CMRF exists to help people during times of acute personal distress. I don't consider spending on education and healthcare as an expenditure but a crucial investment in people.
>
> **A. REVANTH REDDY,** Chief Minister

The present government, he says, has stopped issuing LoCs to private hospitals to encourage patients to seek treatment at government facilities. However, patients requiring specialised treatment unavailable at NIMS or MNJ Cancer Hospital are referred to Basavatarakam.

"Since the hospital is run by a trust and specialises in treating complex cancer cases, LoCs are issued to it. We give ₹5 lakh in one go. Further assistance depends on the requirement," he adds.

For Perika Madhu Kumar, 55, a construction worker from Domalapally in Nalgonda district, the assistance meant avoiding a high-interest loan to pay for treatment. He suffered a heart attack in September and was rushed to NIMS, where doctors found blockages in three coronary arteries. He underwent bypass surgery on September 23, with ₹2.5 lakh provided through an LoC.

"I could not have afforded the treatment without the assistance. Had I borrowed money from a private lender, my family would have had to spend years repaying the loan," he says.

Where assistance goes

Official figures show that the previous government, led by the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), formerly the Telangana Rashtra Samithi, provided ₹2,681.33 crore to 6,37,985 beneficiaries under the CMRF between June 2, 2014, and December 6, 2023.

Another ₹511.59 crore was disbursed through LoCs in 31,324 cases, taking the total to ₹3,192.59 crore.

The annual average of assistance under the present Congress government is substantially higher. In two years and 10 months, it disbursed ₹2,670 crore, averaging approximately ₹943 crore a year, against ₹335 crore annually during the BRS government's nine-and-a-half-year tenure, an increase of nearly 181%.

Even if one excludes two years of the COVID-19 pandemic, when disbursements under the previous government were relatively lower, the yearly average works out to around ₹425 crore. Even so, the present government's annual average of ₹943 crore is nearly 122% higher.

Any person holding a white ration card or an income certificate showing annual income below ₹2 lakh is eligible for assistance. A recommendation letter from an elected public representative, such as an MLA or MLC, or an adviser holding Cabinet rank, is mandatory.

Vemula says the amounts estimated by hospitals are disbursed after verification and that, in nearly 99% of cases, the assistance is sufficient to cover treatment costs. Patients can receive LoCs more than once, depending on the nature and duration of their treatment.

Data show that legislators from both the ruling Congress and Opposition parties have issued recommendation letters for CMRF assistance.

The government maintains that applications carry no political preference, with those recommended by ruling party legislators receiving neither priority nor preferential treatment over those backed by Opposition leaders.

"Helping those in need, irrespective of political affiliations, is the Chief Minister's objective. There is no distinction based on party or individual when it comes to medical treatment. There is also no upper limit on assistance," he adds.

Vemulawada MLA and Government Whip Aadi Srinivas issued the highest number of letters at 13,374, followed by Husnabad MLA and Minister Ponnam Prabhakar with 12,619, Nizamabad Rural MLA R. Bhoopathi Reddy with 12,160, Siddipet MLA and former minister T. Harish Rao with 10,201, and Dharmapuri MLA and Minister A. Laxman Kumar with 8,340.

Manthani MLA and Minister D. Sridhar Babu issued 7,879 letters while Sircilla MLA and former minister K.T. Rama Rao issued 6,428. Medchal MLA Ch. Malla Reddy issued 2,924, while AIMIM's Chandrayangutta MLA Akbaruddin Owaisi issued 41.

> I could not have afforded my bypass surgery without the ₹2.5-lakh assistance from CMRF. Had I borrowed money from a private lender, my family would have had to spend years repaying the loan.
>
> **PERIKA MADHU KUMAR,** A construction worker

In Chief Minister Revanth Reddy's Kodangal constituency, 4,189 recommendation letters were issued in the name of a Special Officer. Former Chief Minister and Gajwel MLA K. Chandrashekar Rao issued 337 letters during the present government's tenure, while his daughter and MLC K. Kavitha issued 630.

Officials say most cases involve heart ailments, cancer, liver and neurological disorders, and injuries sustained in road accidents.

Bridging healthcare gaps

Speaking exclusively, Mr. Revanth Reddy says his government has doubled the Rajiv Aarogyasri health cover to ₹10 lakh per family annually. However, it identified a gap that needed urgent attention: unlike education, healthcare comes with emergencies, he adds.

"The CMRF has been a very effective tool and vehicle for this. Just like the National Disaster Response Fund is meant to support natural or man-made disasters, the CMRF exists to help people during times of acute personal distress," he says, describing the scheme as another example of the humane side of his government.

Education and healthcare are the State government's two biggest priorities, he says: "I don't consider spending on education and healthcare as an expenditure but a crucial investment in people."

Since taking office in December 2023, his government has been investing in healthcare infrastructure. "From adding 10,000 beds in big hospitals in Hyderabad and Warangal to building a new Osmania General Hospital, we are investing heavily in increasing bed capacity in the State," he says.

Vemula says the Chief Minister personally approves applications for financial assistance, a mandatory step before funds can be released. The applications are compiled and placed before him, usually once a month.

"We compile 1,000 cases into a single file. Each file contains a list of beneficiaries whose applications have been processed, and he signs the last sheet. He signs dozens of such sheets once a month on priority," he says.

Scrutiny and safeguards

He says the entire application and disbursal process is online and transparent, leaving no scope for fund misuse. However, there have been reports of alleged irregularities.

Last year, Jubilee Hills police arrested 13 persons for allegedly misappropriating ₹8.71 lakh through fraudulent CMRF cheques. In another case, the Telangana Crime Investigation Department (CID) registered cases against 17 private hospitals in August 2024 for allegedly submitting fake medical bills and treatment records to claim CMRF funds.

"The current dispensation is very particular about such incidents. We verify each and every bill, and even if a minor discrepancy is found, we flag it, particularly in CMRF claims. We ensure there are no irregularities," he says.

Vemula adds that the CMRF provides a maximum of ₹60,000 as reimbursement for medical expenses already incurred by patients or their families, while LoCs cover treatment costs during hospitalisation. Patients can seek reimbursement after treatment at a hospital of their choice by submitting medical bills and other documents.

"Whatever the amount, the assistance provides some relief to families. However, our first priority is to encourage patients to seek treatment at government hospitals," he asserts.

For Swapna Bandhari, a homemaker from Suraram, both her daughters, aged three years and 19 months, have hearing impairments. The elder one has undergone surgery and received a cochlear implant while the younger one is awaiting the procedure.

The family has received LoCs worth more than ₹4 lakh towards treatment.

"The surgery and the treatment that follows are very expensive, and we could never have afforded them on our own. The assistance came as a huge relief to our family and has given my daughters a chance at a better life," she says.

Children like Swapna's daughters are among those the CMRF team is trying to identify and help, particularly in rural areas where hearing impairments may go undetected. This is one reason more than ₹19 crore has been disbursed to the Government ENT Hospital in Koti, says Vemula.

"We are working with public representatives, Anganwadi and Accredited Social Health Activists to identify such children, particularly in rural areas. We are arranging their treatment at the ENT Hospital and providing cochlear implants and other necessary assistance," he says.

Beyond healthcare, the CMRF also extends assistance to students in need, accident victims and farmers who have lost crops or cattle to wild animals.

"There is no fixed budgetary limit for such assistance, and we have extended support in 413 cases so far. We also identify people in need through newspaper reports and reach out to them. Those who donate to the CMRF can be assured that every penny reaches the needy without being misused," Vemula says.

The morphing menace

Increasing instances of morphing and deepfakes involving sexually explicit images and creation of non-consensual intimate images using bots and AI have emerged as a major privacy concern in Keralam. **G. Ragesh** finds out what is happening in the murky world of cybercrimes



ILLUSTRATION: SATHEESH VELLINEZHI

The atmosphere on the campus was volatile, and the tension palpable. Anger was writ large on the faces of students at a prominent college in central Keralam as they staged a sit-in protest outside the administrative office.

The slogans echoed the students' agony and outrage. The situation started slipping out of control as the agitated students threatened to take the law into their own hands. The college authorities had to seek the help of the police to manage the situation, as the student unrest showed early signs of turning violent. The agitation, feared the college authorities, may evolve into a law-and-order situation.

A huge posse of police arrived at the gate of the campus, anticipating trouble. The number of onlookers on the street swelled as the police and students came face to face. The timely intervention of some senior police officers and college authorities eased the situation and consoled the agitated students. Yet, no one blamed the students, who had ample reason to agitate. Most people supported the protesters.

To their utter shock and disbelief, the students had discovered that one of their collegemates had allegedly morphed obscene images of some fellow students and teachers and uploaded it online. "A sense of shock prevailed among the students, and a protest seeking strict action against the alleged culprit was their natural response," recollects Anna*, a student who was part of the agitation.

The college, on its part, had dismissed the student soon after it *prima facie* found substance in the allegations and moved a police complaint, leading to his arrest.

A subdued version of the agitation, meanwhile, played out in a closed-door meeting called by the management. "Will he really get the punishment he deserves for what he has done?" one of the teachers who was affected by her student's "unbelievable" act kept asking.

"The teachers did not break down. They were in shock, and justifiably agitated," remembers an official aware of what transpired behind the doors.

The college authorities shifted classes online for a few days following the shocking incident. They also arranged counselling sessions for restoring the confidence of the affected sections. "The teachers were not ready to face the students immediately," the official says.

Identical crimes

In the following days, a similar crime was reported from an engineering college in central Keralam, leading to the arrest of a student. A medical college in southern Keralam too had witnessed a similar episode in July this year. Allegations of morphing of photographs have come up from at least 12 institutions from across the State in the past few months.

> AI has opened an avenue for everyone to manipulate anything
>
> **NANDAKISHORE HARIKUMAR**
> Cybersecurity expert

Police sources say such incidents are not isolated cases. The State has been witnessing a steady rise in the number of cases relating to morphing or deepfake and non-consensual intimate image (NCII) abuse for the past few years.

While the number of such cases recorded in 2022 was only 19, it rose to 44 and 73 in 2023 and 2024, respectively. Eighty such cases were reported in 2025, and 79 in 2026 till mid-October. Of the 159 cases registered since 2025, 141 pertained to morphing. The rest are NCII abuse cases wherein genuine private images and videos were captured or obtained and shared without the victim's consent.

As many as 251 women and 89 children were targeted by the perpetrators in the past five years while 31 men were also victimised. Almost every police district in the State has reported such cases, though Ernakulam City and Thiruvananthapuram Rural top the list. The motives identified in the cases include monetary gains, defamation, revenge, sexual coercion and gratification, and matrimonial disputes.

"In most of the cases, the victims did nothing to expose themselves. A smiling selfie, a profile picture, a photograph in a dance costume, a group photo from an Onam celebration at college, a picture taken at a temple, or a family wedding photograph was enough for the accused," explains P. Prakash, Inspector General of Police, State Crime Records Bureau.

Disturbing trends

The police identify three trends from the data.

First, the number of money-driven cases is falling while personal and sexual motives are rising. Second, the number of cases originating from schools, colleges and tuition centres more than doubled in 2026.

Third, the use of AI tools, chatbots and nudify bots is increasingly making the crimes easier. Loan-app gangs were also involved in a few incidents, according to the police.

Experts and law enforcers attribute the disturbing scenario mainly to the fast evolution of generative artificial intelligence (AI). "AI has opened an avenue for everyone to manipulate anything," rues Kochi-based cybersecurity expert Nandakishore Harikumar. "Earlier, one had to possess some technical skills to morph an image. Also, the platforms used for such acts required users to log in and make payments. Now, there are thousands of Telegram bots ready to convert any image as a user wishes to see. They are run either by individuals or groups spread across the world. The bots help the perpetrators remain anonymous and do financial transactions in cryptocurrency, making investigation into such cases challenging," he says.

"AI-related cases are new, and the investigation is challenging at times," admits an officer with the Kochi City police. "However, what the perpetrators don't realise is that we are also patrolling the platforms where they think they are safe," he warns.

The officer, who is involved in the investigation into the September campus case, says the major challenge lies in establishing that the offensive contents were created and established by the accused. "However, on the positive side, with the advancements of cyber forensic technologies, the investigators can present conclusive evidence before the courts," he says.

Delay in obtaining metadata

He also points to the difficulty and delay in getting metadata from the platforms concerned which affect the probe. Metadata in cyber investigations refers to 'data about data' or technical information about the characteristics, context, and history of a digital file or network event.

Legal experts echo the concern. "Most of the platforms don't share the metadata with the police promptly. Investigation into the cases involving perpetrators based out of other countries also face several difficulties," says Jiyas Jamal, a cyber law expert based in Kochi. He also blames social media and encrypted messaging platforms for not taking down offensive or abusive content promptly.

"IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021 stipulate that the hosting platforms concerned should remove or disable access to content which involves full/partial nudity, exposing the private area and artificially morphed images of an individual within two hours from the receipt of a complaint made by an individual. However, this is barely followed. Often, the complaints go to the Grievance Appellate Committee. It is estimated that around 2 lakh such appeals are pending with the panel," Jamal notes.

The founder of a cybersecurity-related NGO, Jiyas also calls for strengthening the cyber forensic facilities in the State and setting up special courts for sensitive cybercrimes for the timely completion of trial. Amid the investigative challenges and regulatory non-compliance stands a host of helpless survivors.

Among them is a young woman in southern Keralam who started fearing smiles from strangers. The woman who had an active social life was shattered when she learned that a classmate of hers had morphed a video of hers and circulated it online.

"The incident triggered an acute stress reaction in the woman. She started having nightmares. It reached a point where she started getting panic attacks if some strangers smiled at her. She was worried that the stranger had seen the video and identified her. She ended up in a severe stage of depression from which she is recovering," a psychiatrist, who did not wish to be named, recounts.

"The offender is usually someone the victim knows. Strangers and organised gangs are responsible for only a small share of morphing cases, mostly those committed for money," says Prakash, who is also heading the Cyber Operations wing of the State police. "The offenders in such crimes are often socially isolated and their social circles could be limited," the psychiatrist adds.

Social disconnection among youth

Dr. Arun B. Nair, Department of Psychiatry, Govt. Medical College Hospital, Thiruvananthapuram, identifies the rise in such crimes as part of the increasing social disconnection syndrome among the youth.

"With the overarching influence of social media and AI on our lives, people are increasingly becoming less empathetic. Overexposure to adult content even during the developing stage, between 12 and 25, and normalisation of pornography even in regional languages are also adding to the problem," he explains.

He advocates early intervention from schools and homes as a possible remedy to discourage youth from misuse of technology. "Mental health, legal and cyber hygiene literacy have to be inculcated among children and youth. Parents and guardians must spend quality time with children and discourage them from staying alone. Children should be taught why certain things or behaviour could turn into unhealthy choices in life," he advises. Technology, which has made life easier, could also ruin lives when misused by miscreants.

**Name changed*

INBRIEF



BYD brings luxury electric brand Denza into India

Chinese EV major BYD has introduced its luxury electric brand Denza in India with the launch of two models – D9, a luxury multi-purpose vehicle (MPV) starting at an ex-showroom price of ₹90 lakh, and Z9 GT, a sports car, starting ₹1.57 crore, ex-showroom. The company will have dedicated showrooms for the Denza brand in six cities namely Mumbai, Gurugram, Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Chennai and Hyderabad. Bookings are open at a down payment of ₹10 lakh.

Stock markets snap three-day rally on policy rate hike fears

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Friday, snapping a three-day rally amid expectations of an RBI policy rate hike next month after retail inflation surged to 6.09% in October. Sensex dropped 318.56 points, or 0.39%, to settle at 81,592.45. During the day, it tumbled 622.26 points, or 0.75%, to 81,288.75. NSE Nifty closed 155.05 points, or 0.61%, lower at 25,144.30. This is the first major decline for both benchmark indices this month. PTI

India's forex reserves jump $2.49 billion to $719.547 billion

India's forex reserves increased by $2.49 billion to $719.547 billion during the week ended November 6, according to RBI data released on Friday. The reserves had touched an all-time high of $785.706 billion during the week ended September 4, driven by a heavy flow of currency as part of a special concessional swap for deposits from the diaspora through which banks raised a record $133 billion, but had been on a decline ever since. PTI

Tata feud: Venu, Vijay Singh hit back at Khambata

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Tata Trusts Vice-Chairmen Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh have launched a strong rebuttal to fellow trustee Darius Khambata's criticism of the Tata Sons board's September 17 decisions, accusing him of presenting an incomplete account of the dispute.

In a five-page letter dated November 11, Mr. Srinivasan and Mr. Singh challenged Mr. Khambata's arguments on the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) regulatory position, the proposed listing of Tata Sons, the fiduciary responsibilities of Trust nominees, and the circumstances surrounding the reappointment of Chairman N. Chandrasekaran.

Tata Sons turns down Noel's request for board meet clips

The Tata Trusts Chairman had sought an audio-video recording of the Sept. 17 proceedings in which N. Chandrasekaran was reappointed as chairman of the conglomerate's holding company

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Tata Sons has rejected Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata's request for sharing an audio-video recording of proceedings of a board meeting held on September 17 in which N Chandrasekaran was reappointed as the chairman of the largest conglomerate's holding company.

Mr. Noel, the only dissenter on the vote for the reappointment, had sought the recordings through a series of communications to Tata Sons since the board meeting, which brought out the differences between the top echelons of the salt-to-software group, with the management of Tata Sons on one side and its biggest shareholder on the other.



The company has never had a practice of sharing audio/video recording of in-person meeting, read a communication. REUTERS

"Video recording is mandated when one or more Directors attend online. Company has never in the past had a practice of sharing audio/ video recording of in-person meeting," Tata Sons' company secretary Suprakash Mukhopadhyay wrote to Tata Trusts on November 9.

The recording is not required to be either retained or shared with anybody, including directors, the letter reads.

Emails sent to Tata Sons and Tata Trusts went unanswered.

The November 9 communication also said that draft minutes of the meeting were uploaded on the board's app on October 1, and the "required changes" have been carried out in the minutes after receipt of a reply on October 8.

A copy of the amended minutes will be uploaded on the app, and the directors can raise issues on the same when they are placed before the board for confirmation at its next meeting.

Paytm gets RBI's nod to revive wallet business

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

One97 Communications, the parent company of Paytm Payments Services Ltd., on Friday said it had received in-principle approval from the RBI to operate prepaid payment instruments (PPIs), paving the way for a possible revival of its wallet business.

PPIs allow users to store money in advance in digital wallets and use it to purchase goods and services, transfer funds and make remittances. During Q1 of FY27, the company had disclosed that it had applied for a full-fledged PPI licence. However, it will have to meet the conditions prescribed by the central bank before securing final authorisation.

Mittal says India should retain control over satellite 'Kill Switch'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Bharti Airtel founder and chairman Sunil Bharti Mittal has called for India to retain control over the "kill switch" for satellite communications operating in the country, warning against dependence on a single foreign provider as the government weighs security conditions for the launch of satellite broadband services.

"The kill switch, as we call it, should not be sitting somewhere else. India must have control over its own space destiny," Mr. Mittal said in an interview with PTI marking the 50th anniversary of Bharti Enterprises.

His remarks come amid an increasingly public contest between satellite operators seeking access to India's potentially vast market, with Elon Musk's Starlink and Bharti-backed Eutelsat OneWeb awaiting regulatory clearances to begin commercial operations.

The comments also acquire significance against the backdrop of a growing dispute over Starlink's entry into India.

Mr. Mittal said OneWeb's ground infrastructure had been ready for three years and its satellites had been hovering over India for five years, but the company was still awaiting the government's signal to begin commercial services.

PV wholesales cross 5 lakh units in October, jump 12% YoY: SIAM

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Domestic passenger vehicle (PV) wholesales crossed the 5-lakh milestone for the first time in October, reaching a record 5.19 lakh units, up 12.4% from the corresponding month last year, according to data released by the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM).

Two-wheeler wholesales rose 16.1% YoY to 25.78 lakh units, while three-wheeler dispatches grew 25.7% to 1.03 lakh units during the month.


Two-wheeler wholesales rose 16.1% YoY to 25.78 lakh units

"The Indian automobile industry continues to witness healthy demand momentum," said SIAM Director General Rajesh Menon.

"In the two-wheeler segment, demand continues to be supported by improved credit availability and replacement demand, across both rural and urban markets. For three-wheelers, last-mile mobility requirements and rapid electrification remain strong structural drivers. Overall, the demand outlook remains positive," Mr. Menon added.

'Oil India on track to achieve 4 MMT of crude oil output'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Stepping on gas: The oil and gas explorer is also expecting a modest rise in natural gas output in FY27. COMPANY WEBSITE

Oil India is confident of achieving crude oil output target of 4 million metric tonne (MMT) in FY27, with production expected to rise further in succeeding years, company officials said during an analyst call.

"The point is we are on a path to four and are very confident we will achieve [the same] this year. Our internal targets are a little bit more, but we are targeting four and are on that path," officials said.

The State-owned oil and gas explorer is also expecting a modest rise in natural gas output in FY27. However, a significant boost is anticipated after commissioning the Duliajan feeder line in about 18-20 months.

Meanwhile, Numaligarh Refinery, a material subsidiary, is eyeing ₹6,000 crore capex in FY28 as it moves towards completing ongoing projects.

Capex goal

For FY27, the refinery is on track to achieve capex target of ₹7,500 crore. In an interaction with *The Hindu* in May, Ranjith Rath, Oil India chief, mentioned the Duliajan feeder line would allow for more gas to be evacuated.

He mentioned output would get a major boost, thus, addressing an imperative infrastructural need.

He explained the feeder line would also help evacuate more gas out of associated wells viz wells where oil and gas are present.

Climate of protest



Fund crunch: Activists raise slogans during a protest with the theme "debt cancellation is the secret ingredient for climate justice" organised by ActionAid International Foundation outside the COP31 venue at the Antalya Expo Center of Antalya, on November 13m on the sidelines of the 31st United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP31). AFP

Copper prices slip amid U.S. rate hike fear, less AI need

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Global benchmark prices of copper slid to an almost nearly four-month low Friday amid expectations of U.S. Fed raising interest rates and lower demand especially from China and the technology industry.

At the time of writing, copper was trading about 1.8% lower than the previous day's close at $13,461.99 per tonne.

"The fall in copper prices is mainly due to stronger U.S. dollar, expectations of higher U.S. interest rates and concerns over weaker industrial demand, particularly from China," Federation of Indian Mineral Industries told *The Hindu*.

KPMG to tap $40-bn India sport potential

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU



The hub will tackle challenges through practical solutions.

KPMG in India opened Sports Technology Hub, a platform designed to help sports organisations in the country accelerate digital transformation, unlock new growth opportunities and build future-ready sporting ecosystems.

This is expected to bring together emerging technologies, industry expertise, and practical use cases to address evolving business and operational challenges in the sports industry.

"Fragmented data, legacy infrastructure, operational inefficiencies and rising expectations for personalised experiences continue to hinder innovation." The Sports Technology Hub in Bengaluru aims to address these challenges through practical solutions that sports organisations can evaluate and adopt, KPMG said.

'India will respect duty concessions on Scotch whisky imports from U.K.'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India will honour duty concessions offered on bulk Scotch whisky imports from the U.K. under its trade deal, and the issue will be resolved in the next few days, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Friday. The Department of Revenue in the Finance Ministry is engaged with the stakeholders on the issue, he said.

Ambiguity had arisen as to whether bulk Scotch should be classified under Chapter 22, Heading 2208, which specifically covers spirits and whisky or Heading 2106, relating to food preparations not elsewhere specified or included.



Minor irritant: A salesman arranges liquor bottles inside a liquor store in Bengaluru, India. REUTERS

The India-U.K. trade agreement, implemented in July this year, provides lower customs duties on whisky, including bulk Scotch whisky imported in containers of more than two litre. The duty has been reduced from 150% to 75% when the agreement came into force on July 15 and will be further cut to 40% over 10 years.

Technical issues

Replying to reporters, the Commerce Secretary said there are certain technical issues involved in the import of Scotch whisky.

"I think Department of Revenue is very closely engaged with the stakeholders, and they are trying to resolve it.

"It is largely a classification issue as the duties in three potential lines where the Scotch can come in are very different... But I am sure it will be resolved very soon," the Commerce Secretary added.

CCPA fines Ola ₹10 lakh for pre-ride 'tip'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) imposed a penalty of ₹10 lakh on ANI Technologies Private Ltd., which operates ride-hailing platform Ola, for soliciting additional payments from customers before their journeys were completed.

The regulator said the pre-ride 'tip' or 'add-on' feature misled consumers, amounted to an unfair trade practice and employed a dark pattern.

The order, passed by Chief Commissioner Nidhi Khare and Commissioner Anupam Mishra, directed Ola to discontinue the practice immediately.



The pre-ride 'tip' employed a dark pattern, the CCPA said

The company has been asked to ensure strict compliance with the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, the Dark Patterns Guidelines, 2023, and the Guidelines for Prevention of Misleading Advertisements and Endorsements for Misleading Advertisements, 2022.

DAMASCUS

Syria removes visa restrictions on U.S. travellers after backlash



AFP

Syria has lifted restrictions on the entry of U.S. citizens imposed several days ago, after the limits sparked uproar online. The current Syrian government, in place since Islamist-led fighters overthrew Bashar al-Assad in December 2024, has allowed Westerners to obtain entry visas at Damascus airport or border crossings. AFP

MOSCOW

Ukraine fires almost 1,200 drones at Russian targets, kills at least four



AP

Ukraine fired almost 1,200 drones at Russian targets overnight in one of its biggest aerial attacks since Moscow's invasion nearly five years ago. An attack on an industrial facility in the central Russian region of Samara killed four people on Friday, the regional governor said, without providing further details. AFP

JERUSALEM

Eisenkot calls for respect for Arab minority after right-wing attacks



AFP

Israeli Prime Ministerial hopeful Gadi Eisenkot called on Friday for respect for the country's Arab minority after caretaker premier Benjamin Netanyahu and other right-wing figures sought to delegitimise the community's lawmakers by linking them to Hamas. "Arab citizens of Israel are an integral part of the Israeli story." AFP

ISTANBUL

Turkiye, Qatar sign mutual defence agreement to further regional ties



REUTERS

Turkiye and Qatar signed a mutual defence agreement on Friday that President Recep Tayyip Erdogan said would further strengthen ties between the regional allies and "prevent the resurgence of war in the Gulf region", his office said. Mr. Erdogan met Qatari Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani in Istanbul. AFP

Iran's IRGC claims it targeted a U.S. radar in Bahrain in retaliatory strike

U.S. Central Command denies the radar was destroyed, and says it intercepted two one-way drones; while Tehran says the Strait of Hormuz is closed, U.S. claims it has opened a southern route for commercial vessels to exit and enter the waters

Stanly Johny



Stern warning: The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps has warned of a 'borderless confrontation' if violations continue. REUTERS

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) on Friday said it had "destroyed" a U.S. military early-warning radar in Bahrain, in retaliation for a U.S. strike on a telecommunications tower in Sirik, southern Iran.

"An hour ago, in response to the enemy's air attack on a telecommunications tower in Sirik, the IRGC's aerospace fighters targeted and destroyed the early-warning radar of the American aggressors on the island of Bahrain," the IRGC said in its statement.

It added that the attack was "a serious warning to the aggressor enemy to end air mischief and oil smuggling in the Strait of Hormuz".

Several hours later, the U.S. military's Central Command denied that the radar had been destroyed and said it intercepted two "one-way attack drones" launched at Bahrain by the Guards.

The U.S. military in recent days had carried out limited air strikes on Qeshm island and other parts of southern Iran near the strait, which it said were "defensive in nature".

October saw a record spike in maritime attacks in the Strait of Hormuz with nearly three dozen tankers being hit. The IRGC says the strait is closed, while the U.S. Navy claims that it has opened a southern route for commercial vessels to exit and enter the critical waterway, while maintaining its "ironclad blockade" of Iranian ports. In the first week of November, at least six vessels came under attack in the strait, according to the UKMTO. The U.S. says its strikes in southern Iran were aimed at neutralising the threats the IRGC posed to maritime traffic.

"In case of repeated violations and aggressions, the IRGC's air force is on full alert for borderless confrontation," the Guards said.

Iran's chief of the general staff Maj. Gen. Ali Abdollahi said any miscalculation by the U.S. and Israel will be met with "devastating strikes". "We warn the United States and the Zionist regime once again that the previous slaps were only the beginning of the story, and in the event of any new miscalculation, far more lethal blows await them," he stated.

China stages unannounced Pacific drills around Taiwan

Reuters
TAIPEI



A Taiwanese coast guard ship monitoring a Chinese coast guard ship off Taiwan's northeastern coast. AFP/FILE PHOTO

China carried out a large, unannounced military exercise across the western Pacific and around Taiwan in early November, in what officials in Taipei have described as a campaign of "silent intimidation" aimed at pressuring Taiwan and other governments before major international meetings.

A senior Taiwan security official, speaking on condition of anonymity due to the sensitivity of the matter, said China's military and coast guard had at one point massed more than 100 vessels in the region early this month, conducting drills that included simulated attacks on other militaries and cities including Taiwan's.

The naval deployment was larger than "Justice Mission 2025", China's last formally named drills targeting Taiwan nearly a year ago and one of the largest Chinese naval deployments to date, the official said.

The drills come as China, which views democratically governed Taiwan as its own territory, has stepped up its military pressure over the past five years, drawing condemnation from Taipei and heightening concern in Western capitals about the potential for conflict.

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Thursday gave a major policy speech about Taiwan, urging peaceful "reunification" though making no mention of using force.

ICC judges limit Afghanistan probe to crimes by Taliban

Associated Press
THE HAGUE

Judges at the International Criminal Court have ended the part of the global tribunal's investigation into Afghanistan that could have involved U.S. military personnel, instead limiting the probe to crimes committed by the Taliban, according to court filings released on Friday.

The ruling comes as the court and 13 current and former staff members are under sanctions by the Trump administration, which is opposed to any investigation into American citizens or U.S. allies, such as Israel.

The decision, which was issued on Thursday but only made public on Friday, cites "significant limitations to the Prosecution's ability to conduct its investigations and secure evidence" in the case. It does not elaborate.

The United States is not a member of the court and does not recognise its jurisdiction

The court's prosecutor's office said it has already appealed the decision.

It is not clear if the decision will mitigate Washington's attacks on the court. Secretary of State Marco Rubio has threatened to "dismantle the ICC – brick by brick, if necessary". The United States is not a member of the court and does not recognise its jurisdiction.

But the U.S. has also taken issue with the ICC's investigation into Israeli officials. The court has outstanding arrest warrants for Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, as well as his former Defence Minister, over allegations of crimes against humanity in Gaza. They have strongly rejected the accusations. Judges at the global court authorised an investigation in 2020 covering offences allegedly committed by Afghan government forces, the Taliban, American troops and U.S. foreign intelligence operatives dating back to 2002. Two years later, then-chief prosecutor Karim Khan chose to "deprioritise" aspects of the investigation that could have involved Americans, citing challenges in obtaining evidence. Mr. Khan was ousted over sexual misconduct allegations earlier this year.

The part of the investigation involving the Taliban will be split off into a separate inquiry.

Existential fight



Naji Abu Awad, a Palestinian-American who had just arrived directly from the U.S., and his family scuffle with Israeli soldiers outside his home, which has been under military occupation for 17 days, in Turmus Ayya, in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, on Thursday. AFP

UN extends mission to Cental Africa by one year

Agence France-Presse
UNITED NATIONS

The UN Security Council has voted to extend by a year the mandate of its peacekeeping mission in the Central African Republic (CAR), set to expire this weekend, amid calls for a gradual withdrawal.

The UN stabilisation force in the CAR has already begun scaling back numbers, having been deployed in 2014 during the country's bloody civil war.

But the Security Council voted unanimously to prolong the mandate while maintaining the perspective of a progressive transfer of its authority to the CAR authorities.

This peacekeeping operation currently involves nearly 10,000 military personnel, according to UN.

Pakistan calls for end to Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia at UN

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

Pakistan has called for the "immediate and unconditional" cessation of Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia as the UN Security Council renewed targeted sanctions under its Yemen sanctions regime for another year.

The Security Council unanimously adopted the resolution on Thursday.

According to a report in *Dawn*, Pakistan's Permanent Representative to the UN Ambassador Syed Haider Shah, while explaining his country's vote in favour of the resolution, said that Islamabad "condemns in the strongest terms" the continued Houthi attacks against Saudi Arabia.

'Resolute support'

"We stand in full and unwavering solidarity with the leadership, government and brotherly people of Saudi Arabia. Our support for the kingdom's sovereignty, territorial integrity, security and stability is resolute," Mr. Shah said.

Pakistan's Army says it killed 74 militants in raids on their hideouts; car bomb kills 5

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD



The raids were carried out in the Mir Ali and Orakzai districts in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. AFP

Pakistani security forces have killed 74 militants in multiple raids on hideouts in the northwest and southwestern regions bordering Afghanistan over the past 10 days, the military said on Friday.

The raids were carried out in the Mir Ali and Orakzai districts in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the military said in a statement. Troops killed 43 militants and seized weapons, ammunition and explosive devices, the statement said. Separately, troops killed 31 militants in multiple operations in Balochistan province, the site of a bloody insurgency led by the outlawed Baloch Liberation Army, since November 3, the military said. It alleged the militants were backed by Afghanistan and India. Kabul and New Delhi have previously denied such allegations.

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif vowed to continue the fight against militancy.

Meanwhile, five people were killed and 13 injured in a car bombing at a security checkpoint in Pakistan's Balochistan province, a security official said.

The attack took place on Thursday in the Kandawa area of Mastung district. The banned Baloch Liberation Army claimed responsibility for the attack.

China's access to Nvidia chips in doubt as curbs gain traction

Reuters
WASHINGTON

U.S. House Speaker Mike Johnson said on Thursday there was growing consensus in Congress on limiting chip exports to China after a spy scandal forced out Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang.

Lawmakers from both parties have since called for tougher restrictions on China's access to advanced AI chips, threatening access to chips that underpin China's surging AI development.

"The export controls on chips to China has been a big issue around here," Johnson, a Louisiana Republican, told reporters at the U.S. Capitol, adding he favoured limiting China's access to the advanced technology. "I think there's a developing consensus in Congress that is an important position to take."

The case has revived claims among China critics in Washington that U.S. export policies are too weak, boosting calls for more restrictions.



Little pontiff: A baby is dressed in the papal attire on the occasion of Pope Leo's visit to Peru on Thursday. REUTERS

Peru's centuries-old Eucharistic 'miracle' awaits Pope's nod

Reuters
CHICLAYO

As Pope Leo returns on Friday to Chiclayo, Peru, where he once served as bishop, residents of a nearby town hope he will revive a cause he once championed – Vatican recognition of a Eucharistic miracle they believe occurred nearly four centuries ago.

In Eten, a northern town near the Pacific Ocean, residents say the child Jesus appeared twice in 1649 in a consecrated host, the wafer Catholics believe becomes the body of Christ. The host is part of the Eucharist, the Catholic rite commemorating the Last Supper.

Long before he became Pope, Robert Prevost, as Leo was known, put down deep roots in Peru. The Chicago-born missionary arrived in the country in 1985, became a Peruvian citizen in 2015, and served as bishop of Chiclayo from 2015 until 2023.

In Chiclayo, Prevost took up the cause of Eten's centuries-old story himself. In 2019, as bishop, he presented Pope Francis with a proposal for the Vatican to recognise the "Eucharistic miracle", backed by historical records and thousands of testimonies of faith, according to the Catholic Church in Chiclayo.

Such recognition is rare and requires a lengthy Church investigation. As bishop, Prevost sometimes celebrated Masses honouring the purported Eten apparition, witnesses said, and secured more than 11 hectares (27 acres) for the Diocese of Chiclayo at the site of the church where residents say the miracle occurred. The diocese planned to build Peru's first Eucharistic sanctuary.

Much of the church has vanished beneath the earth. Archaeologist Jorge Alberto Centurión, who excavated the site in 2009 and 2010, said his team uncovered remnants of its entrance and evidence of burials inside.

Europe wants a seat at Ukraine peace talks but divided on who should lead

Whether the continent should be represented by one person or a team, and who should do it is being debated as leaders meet in Dublin on Friday; nevertheless, governments from U.K. to Ukraine agree on need for Europe to join the ongoing negotiations involving Moscow, Kyiv, and Washington

Associated Press
DUBLIN

European nations are seeking an envoy to represent them in talks on ending the Russia-Ukraine war, concerned that a U.S.-backed process will leave them sidelined and Kyiv vulnerable as Moscow and Washington decide the fate of a conflict that has roiled the continent.

Whether Europe should be represented by one person or a team – and who should take on the role – is being debated Friday as leaders from the 27-nation European Union (EU) meet at a summit in Dublin. Senior EU officials and politicians have been suggested, but there has been no consensus yet. What the job might entail is also unclear and contested. But there is broad agreement by governments from the U.K. to Ukraine on the need for Europe to join the ongoing negotiations involving Moscow, Kyiv, and Washington.

"This needs to be resolved," Irish Prime Minister Micheál Martin said as he arrived at the summit. "I would hope that today's discussions bring clarity around this," he said. "It needs to be, in my view, finally decided upon within the next week or two."

Ukraine is eager for support from its European allies. It's reluctant to leave the talks solely in the hands of a U.S. administration that has often seemed to lean toward Moscow. Russia does not want European countries involved in direct negotiations, complaining they are financing and supplying Ukraine's military effort.

European leaders also distrust U.S. President Donald Trump after a series of tense stand-offs over trade, Greenland, and conflicts in Iran and Ukraine.

European leaders fear Russian President Vladimir Putin will press Mr. Trump to back a peace settlement that weakens not just Ukraine but also broader European security. Mr. Putin has demanded NATO troops be pulled back from Russia's borders and that no European forces be deployed in Ukraine.

As envoys from Washington, Moscow, and Kyiv met in Abu Dhabi, several European countries, including the U.K., France and Germany, attended discussions nearby.

U.S. envoy Jared Kushner and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said after they met in Dublin late Thursday that Europe would be part of the next talks. "We cannot conclude this deal without the Europeans being at the table," Mr. Kushner said.



Big deal: EU leaders fear Russia will press U.S. to back a truce that weakens not just Ukraine but also wider European security. REUTERS

'Spiders in a jar'

Supporters of a single envoy, like Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, argue that the absence of a united European voice has allowed individual countries or small groups to engage in freelance diplomacy. "There are too many different groupings discussing the issue," she said.

Ms. Meloni has criticised a series of seemingly uncoordinated initiatives, including an October call to Mr. Putin by Finnish President Alexander Stubb and Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre, that she said could undermine European interests.

Mr. Martin said that European representation at the negotiations "can't just be European Union" because the Coalition of the Willing – a group of over two dozen countries that have pledged military support to help maintain a future peace in Ukraine – "has involved far more than the European Union."

"It's a European continentwide issue," he said, pointing to Norway and Britain's support for Ukraine.

Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said Thursday that Europe must first name a representative. "The Europeans squabble like spiders in a jar."

The question of who represents Europe is an old one. Europe itself is loosely defined. Is it the 27-nation EU, the 32-nation NATO military alliance made up mostly of European countries, the 29-nation Schengen zone, or the 47-nation European Political Community? That has long frustrated Washington.

After this week's U.S.-brokered talks in the United Arab Emirates, Mr. Kushner said that "if Europe could identify one person to speak on their behalf, that would be a bigger achievement than getting the Russians to include them in the negotiation."

That echoes the famous question often misattributed to former U.S. Secretary of State Henry Kissinger: "Who do I call if I want to call Europe?"

France, Germany, and the U.K., the region's top three economies collectively known as the European trio, or E3, have so far been the most engaged European group in negotiations. But while London is deeply involved with Ukraine, the U.K. left the EU in 2020.

An E3 envoy would leave out the other 25 EU nations and rankle smaller nations, like those bordering Russia and Belarus on the bloc's eastern flank, which face constant hybrid threats, including influence campaigns and disruptive drones.

Some back a top EU official for the job. Even inside Brussels, however, there are two leading contenders: European Council President Antonio Costa and the EU's top diplomat Kaja Kallas.

"European security cannot be discussed without a European voice at the table," Mr. Costa said in Dublin on Thursday. "That European voice needs to be a team effort between European nations, the European Union, and NATO."

Earlier this year, Mr. Costa faced criticism within the EU after his office set up a hush-hush back-channel with Moscow.

'An anchorage moment'

Ms. Kallas, a former Prime Minister of Estonia, laid claim to the envoy role Friday, saying, "I'm the one who is representing Europe in the foreign and security policy."

"I know that the Russians don't want me, but, you know, do we have a say, who is representing Russia?" she said. "We can't send any person that has no institutional role like the Americans are sending." Another name that has been floated is Mr. Stubb, the Finnish President. He has warm ties with Mr. Trump, and met in Oslo with U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Mr. Kushner in October.

But some leaders deeply distrust the U.S.-brokered talks. Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk was critical of the negotiations, reflecting the pessimism of EU nations formerly dominated by the Soviet Union.

"In my opinion, calling them negotiations is an exaggeration," Mr. Tusk said Thursday. "We will not build a new security architecture simply because the Russian President, or someone in the United States, wishes it."

With Mr. Trump due to head to Beijing next week to meet Mr. Putin, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said European leaders feared another "Anchorage moment," a reference to the Alaska summit where they were stunned by Mr. Trump's overtures to the Russian leader in the absence of Ukrainian or European envoys.

"Please, no surprises," Mr. Merz said. "Continue to play in team Europe and in the team with Ukraine."

Best foot forward



Members of the Maasai community engaged in a traditional performance during a cultural festival in Sekenani, Tanzania, on Friday. AFP

Le Pen seeks to square pension vows with France's budget reality

Reuters
PARIS

France's far-right National Rally (RN) will present its pension plans next Tuesday as it seeks to convince increasingly nervous investors that its programme will be affordable if, as opinion polls suggest, it takes power in five months' time.

Marine Le Pen's party is seeking to uphold its promise of allowing workers who started young to retire at 60 while limiting the costs of unwinding President Emmanuel Macron's unpopular pension overhaul.

Pensions are among France's most politically explosive issues and investors are watching closely for a commitment to raise the retirement age as a sign of fiscal discipline at a time of strained public finances and bond market jitters.



Opinion polls: Marine Le Pen, leader of France's far-right National Rally, is tipped to win the presidential election in the spring. AFP

Ms. Le Pen said last month she would wring €140 billion in savings out of France's budget by the end of the next presidential term in 2032, but has struggled to convince economists and investors that such cuts are achievable.

She has said her pension reforms would save €15 billion to 20 billion a year once fully implemented, a target that could prove hard to achieve if she sticks to longstanding promises to let workers who started particularly young retire at 60.

Ms. Le Pen, tipped to win the presidential election in the spring, has also pledged to repeal Mr. Macron's 2023 reform that would gradually raise the retirement age to 64 from 62. Mr. Macron's overhaul triggered months of protests and left a large share of voters hostile to the reform. The government suspended the plan last year as part of a deal with Socialists to secure parliamentary backing for its budget.

Pensions are by far France's single biggest public expense, set to reach €436 billion next year, or 14% of economic output

Brazil's Bolsonaro shrugs off fugitive label, eyes future Brazil presidential bid

Reuters
WASHINGTON

On his first visit to Washington since losing a presidential election, Flavio Bolsonaro brushed aside doubts about his grip on Brazil's political right and said he was ready to stand for the Liberal Party in the next race, which he argued might come sooner than expected.

Speaking to *Reuters* on Thursday between meetings to sort out his United States immigration status, Mr. Bolsonaro rejected critics – including re-elected President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva – who branded him a runaway for making a dash to the U.S. after last month's vote.

"That is a pejorative way of trying to attack me," he said. "Honestly, I couldn't care less. I am convinced that I needed to be here."

A Quaest opinion poll showed 62% of Brazilians disapproved of him leaving the country after the runoff, which Mr. Lula won by a margin of more than 4 million votes.

The Senator, who was expected to see U.S. officials in Washington, declined to say with whom he was meeting.

Ready to run

The son of former President Jair Bolsonaro – who is serving a 27-year sentence for a coup plot after he lost the 2022 election – said he believes economic problems will cut short Mr. Lula's fourth term.

"Brazil is going to go broke," he said, claiming families were struggling with too much debt and businesses were unwilling to invest in a country with what he said was an unfair legal system. "If a new electoral race emerges, I am ready to return."

Mr. Bolsonaro offered few details about his standing in the right-wing Liberal Party, but said he intended to run under its banner again.

Before fleeing the country, he alleged without evidence that the election had been fraudulent, despite the electoral court declaring Mr. Lula the winner. His political allies have also conceded the result.

Mr. Bolsonaro acknowledged that his post-election legal challenges face long odds.



Political foe: Brazilian Senator Flavio Bolsonaro believes economic problems will cut short President Lula da Silva's 4th term. REUTERS

"If you ask me whether I think they'll go anywhere, I doubt it," he said, accusing the justice system of being in thrall to the government without citing evidence.

He declined to repeat language used in a letter sent shortly after he arrived in the U.S., in which he initially described himself as "President-elect" before the wording was changed to "leader."

Asked whether he regarded himself as the president-elect, Bolsonaro did not answer directly.

"To millions of Brazilians, that's who I am," he said.

Brazil's Supreme Court had ordered Mr. Bolsonaro to surrender his passport before he left the country, citing federal money-laundering investigations and concerns that he might flee. Mr. Bolsonaro travelled with his family to the U.S. via Argentina and Ecuador.

'Grateful to Trump'

He declined to tell *Reuters* who assisted his family during the journey or how the travel was arranged.

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on October 31 that Washington had not been directly involved in Mr. Bolsonaro's departure from Brazil.

Reuters and other media outlets reported last week that Jason Miller, a White House official, helped arrange the journey. Mr. Bolsonaro said he could not discuss matters regarding his flight to the U.S.

He also said he was not afraid of being investigated but believed he would be unfairly treated in Brazil.

Senator Bolsonaro has not met President Donald Trump since arriving in Florida. He said neither the U.S. nor other foreign governments had interfered in Brazil's election.

"He may have had his preference, but he took no action to influence the election results in Brazil," Mr. Bolsonaro said of Mr. Trump. He added that he was grateful to the U.S. President, who declared on October 31 that the Senator could stay in the U.S. as long as he wanted.

Mr. Trump has called the Brazilian election "a disgrace." Outside observers have described it as free and fair.

In the 50-minute interview, the Brazilian leader said he had not decided whether he and his family would remain in Florida, adding that he had the means to support himself in the U.S. as a Senator, lawyer and businessman, but declining to say whether he had transferred money to the country.

BOLT FROM THE BLUE

Shreyas reckons pitch changed drastically in the second innings



AFP

Shreyas Iyer on Friday blamed the change in the pitch for India's 244-run defeat to New Zealand in the fourth ODI, saying it went from a belter to a seaming track. "A tough one, I guess, to take that. There was a huge difference between the wickets between innings," said Shreyas, who captained India in ODIs for the first time.

QUALITY SIDE

We've shown that we can put India under pressure: Henry



AFP

As a bowling unit, we were trying to be relentless. The way we have bowled with the new ball has been fantastic. We have shown that we can take wickets and put India, which is world-class, under pressure. It has the best batting line-up in the world — Matt Henry, New Zealand pacer.

WORRYING SIGNS

Gambhir concerned about India's batting collapses ahead of WC



AFP

You're always concerned when you get bundled out for 90-odd (*sic*). Why won't I be concerned? These are conditions which are going to be closest to what we might get during the World Cup. The bigger concern is not the runs. It's how quickly we got bundled out, around 26 or 27 overs — Gautam Gambhir, India head coach.

MAN IN CHARGE

Manchester United announces Pochettino as new head coach



AP

Manchester United named Mauricio Pochettino as its new head coach on Friday following the dismissal of Michael Carrick. "The club has reached an agreement with the US soccer federation for Mauricio and his staff to be released after conclusion of their responsibilities with the US men's team," the club said.

Young ton, Henry six-for flatten India as Kiwis pull one back

The opening batter makes the visiting side pay dearly for two early drops as the Black Caps rack up 333; the pace spearhead returns career-best figures on his comeback as the Men in Blue get bowled out for 89 in the 27th over

INDIA IN NZ

Agence France-Presse
MOUNT MAUNGANUI

Will Young struck a century and Matt Henry took six wickets as New Zealand thrashed a ragged India by 244 runs in the fourth ODI here on Friday.

Henry removed Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli and Shreyas Iyer all without scoring in the first over of India's chase to tear the top-order apart with the visitor needing a massive 334 for victory.

New Zealand made 333 after being asked to bat as Young punished two simple drops to bring up his fifth ODI hundred.

India never stood a chance of chasing the total after Henry's heavenly opening over.

Rohit edged his first ball to slip, Kohli was bowled off the fourth ball he faced, and then Shreyas was pegged on his back leg to be trapped in front of the wicket.

India's rebuild never happened, Ishan Kishan top-scoring with just 27 as it was shot out for 89.

Henry ended with six for 27 and Matthew Fisher took three for 31.

New Zealand's imposing total came on the back of Young's 125 from 108 balls, including 14 fours and four sixes. Young and Tim Seifert combined for an 85-run opening partnership.



Home heroes: Young rode his luck en route his fifth ODI hundred while Henry rocked India with a triple strike in the first over. AFP

While Young rode his early luck – dropped twice off successive balls when on five in the second over, first by Rohit at slip and then by wicketkeeper Kishan – Seifert played the aggressor with a brisk 39-ball 50. When Seifert fell for 58 (48b, 6x4, 3x6), Nick Kelly and Dean Foxcroft soon followed playing reckless shots.

Young found better support in Finn Allen, the two putting on 90 runs off just 65 balls as they cashed in on the wayward Indian attack.

Young's first 50 came off 49 balls, and his second from just 39 as he hit regular boundaries through the middle overs.

Allen made 41 from 30 deliveries, including five fours and two sixes.

Axar Patel took two for 39 from 10 overs as India put the brakes on the scoring, while Auqib Nabi had two for 59 and Gurnoor Brar two for 69.

India leads the five-match series 2-1 with the final game to be played at the same venue on Sunday.

SCOREBOARD

NEW ZEALAND
Will Young c sub (Kushagra) b Dhir 125 *(108b, 14x4, 4x6)*, Tim Seifert c Kishan b Gurnoor 58 *(48b, 6x4, 3x6)*, Nick Kelly st. Kishan b Axar 4 *(8b)*, Dean Foxcroft c Gurnoor b Nabi 8 *(13b)*, Finn Allen c Rohit b Axar 41 *(30b, 5x4, 2x6)*, Michael Bracewell c Dhir b Gurnoor 15 *(20b, 1x4)*, Mitchell Santner c Kishan b Arshdeep 24 *(29b, 1x4, 2x6)*, Kristian Clarke lbw b Nabi 22 *(22b, 1x4, 1x6)*, Kyle Jamieson (not out) 19 *(21b, 1x4)*, Matt Henry run out 2 *(2b)*, Matthew Fisher run out 1 *(1b)*; Extras (b-4, lb-5, nb-2, w-3): 14; Total (in 50 overs): 333.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-85 (Seifert, 11.6 overs), 2-96 (Kelly, 14.2), 3-125 (Foxcroft, 19.3), 4-215 (Allen, 30.2), 5-256 (Young, 36.6), 6-258 (Bracewell, 37.5), 7-293 (Santner, 44.2), 8-318 (Clarke, 47.6), 9-332 (Henry, 49.5).

INDIA BOWLING
Arshdeep 10-0-55-1, Nabi 8-0-59-2, Gurnoor 10-0-69-2, Axar 10-0-39-2, Kuldeep 8-0-73-0, Dhir 4-0-29-1.

INDIA
Rohit Sharma c Allen b Henry 0 *(1b)*, Ruturaj Gaikwad c Bracewell b Jamieson 5 *(13b)*, Virat Kohli b Henry 0 *(4b)*, Shreyas Iyer lbw b Henry 0 *(1b)*, Ishan Kishan b Henry 27 *(53b, 4x4)*, Axar Patel c Allen b Fisher 21 *(36b, 3x4)*, Naman Dhir c Santner b Fisher 21 *(24b, 2x6)*, Auqib Nabi c Seifert b Fisher 5 *(8b, 1x4)*, Kuldeep Yadav b Henry 1 *(4b)*, Gurnoor Brar b Henry 2 *(13b)*, Arshdeep Singh (not out) 0 *(3b)*; Extras (w-7): 7; Total (in 26.4 overs): 89.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-0 (Rohit, 0.1), 2-0 (Kohli, 0.5), 3-0 (Shreyas, 0.6), 4-9 (Ruturaj, 5.3), 5-53 (Axar, 17.1), 6-61 (Kishan, 20.1), 7-66 (Nabi, 21.4), 8-69 (Kuldeep, 22.6), 9-83 (Dhir, 23.6).

NEW ZEALAND BOWLING
Henry 9.4-2-27-6, Jamieson 6-2-12-1, Clarke 2-0-13-0, Fisher 7-1-31-3, Bracewell 2-0-6-0.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Henry.
New Zealand won by 244 runs, India ahead 2-1.
Fifth and final ODI: Nov. 15, Mount Maunganui, 7.30 a.m. IST.

Sportstar book celebrates Tendulkar and Kohli's 15,000-run feat in ODIs

Sports Bureau

Only two batters have crossed the 15,000-run mark in ODI cricket: Sachin Tendulkar and Virat Kohli. Separated by generations but united by an extraordinary appetite for runs, the two greats are the subject of *The 15,000 Club: Two Generations, One Summit*, a special publication launched by *Sportstar* on Friday.

The book was formally launched by K.M. Mammen, Chairman and Managing Director of MRF Limited, and Rahul Mammen Mappillai, Managing Director of MRF Limited, in the presence of N. Murali, Chairman of the Board of Directors of *The Hindu* Group Publishing Private Limited (THGPPL), and N. Ram, Director of *The Hindu* Group. Also present were Ramesh Rangaranjan, Director, Kasturi & Sons Limited, and K. Venugopal, KSL Director.

The association between MRF and the two legends has its own place in cricketing history. Tendulkar's iconic 'Desert Storm' knocks in Sharjah in 1998, when he struck 143 and 134 against Australia, remain among the enduring images of his MRF years.

Kohli, too, produced several defining performances with the MRF branding on his bat, including his unbeaten 82 against Pakistan in the 2022 T20 World Cup in Australia.



The launch: K.M. Mammen and N. Murali hold the first copy of *The 15,000 Club: Two Generations, One Summit* at *The Hindu* office in Chennai on Friday. N. Ram and Rahul Mammen Mappillai are also seen. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

K.M. Mammen recalled Tendulkar's early association with the MRF Pace Foundation, where the prodigy had initially arrived hoping to become a fast bowler.

"When Dennis Lillee [the first Director of Coaching at the MRF Pace Foundation] saw him, he didn't want to upset him, but he made him bowl and then said, 'You are promoted.'

But Sachin was so adamant that he came back and said, 'Why don't you try me out for a little bit of batting?' That was when we saw his potential," Mammen said.

He also recalled the financial leap of faith MRF took when it first signed Tendulkar, at a time when the company was still establishing itself.

"When we signed Sachin, he asked for a substantial amount," Mammen said with a laugh. "But we did whatever it took to get him on board, and things just took off from there."

The *15,000 Club* goes beyond milestones and statistics to revisit the careers of the two stalwarts through extracts from original match reports from *The Hindu* and *Sportstar* archives, archival photographs and contemporary accounts.

Interviews with former teammates offer an intimate perspective on their methods, mindsets, personalities and influence in the dressing room.

Tracing Tendulkar's emergence as a wunderkind and Kohli's rise into a modern great, the book explores the continuities between two remarkable careers and the distinct legacies they have left on Indian cricket.

Debutant Beardman demolishes England

Agence France-Presse
PERTH

Mahli Beardman took six for 24 on debut before Mitchell Marsh smashed a 29-ball 50 as Australia crushed England by seven wickets in the first ODI here on Friday.

After Marsh chose to bowl, the 21-year-old Beardman tore through the England batting as the visitor was bundled out for 131 in 33.4 overs.

Beardman bowled with real pace and aggression to record the best ODI bowling figures by an Australian on debut.

Marsh then put the issue beyond doubt with a devastating half-century, hitting four boundaries and clearing the fence another four times to the delight of his home crowd.

The scores: England 131 in 33.4 overs (Johnson 3/42, Beardman 6/24) lost to Australia 132/3 in 23.3 overs (Marsh 50). **Toss:** Australia; **PoM:** Beardman.

Abhimanyu holds his own against Carlsen

TOTAL CHESS

Jayantho Sengupta
BUDAPEST

Abhimanyu Mishra had welcomed the chance to play Magnus Carlsen twice when the Total Chess World Championship Tour pilot's draw was announced. On Thursday, the youngest Grandmaster in the field drew both games against the World No. 1, who had to defend an inferior position in their second meeting.

Abhimanyu, the 17-year-old American with a rating of 2644 to Carlsen's 2823, held firm with black in round three of the Fast Classic group stage. The position in the Italian Game remained balanced despite Carlsen's bishop sacrifice on h6, and a rook exchange on move 50 led to a draw.

Carlsen chose the Scandinavian Defence in the return game, but his position worsened after he moved his king to d7 on move 26. Abhimanyu manoeuvred his knight to h5 and picked up the g7 and h6 pawns, gaining a substantial advantage. Carlsen reached an opposite-coloured bishop ending and held on for an 80-move draw, his fourth in as many games.



No way through: Abhimanyu put on an impressive defensive display. FLICKR.COM

Abhimanyu moved to three points in Group C, one behind Carlsen with six games to go. Ian Nepomniachtchi and Haik Martirosyan shared the lead with six points. Martirosyan and Anish Giri won a game each.

In Group D, Bibisara Assaubayeva (Elo 2532), upset the higher-rated Arjun Erigaisi (2746) with black in round three. Arjun won the return game, also with black, to draw level with Assaubayeva on five points and be placed third. R. Vaishali lost both games to Hans Niemann and stayed last with one point. Niemann joined Maxime Vachier-Lagrave on eight after the Frenchman secured a win and a draw against Wesley So.

R. Praggnanandhaa lost twice to Fabiano Caruana and remained bottom of Group B with two points. Caruana led with 10, two clear of Liem Le, who posted a win and a draw against Vincent Keymer. Alireza Firouzja led Group A with eight points after a win and a draw against Jorden van Foreest.

(The writer is in Budapest at the invitation of Total Chess).

Priyansh, Parneet top qualifiers

ARCHERY

Y.B. Sarangi
SHILLONG

Priyansh and Parneet Kaur bounced back from quieter phases of their respective careers to claim top position in compound men's and women's qualification rounds respectively in the National archery championships at the Parade Ground here on Friday.

Former World youth champion Priyansh shot brilliantly to gather 713, studded with 32 Xs, to beat 18-year-old challenger Mohit Dagar by just one point. Asian Games team gold medallist Kushal Dalal and former World champion Ojas Deotale took third and fourth spots with 710 and 707, respectively.

Parneet totalled 710 with the help of 28 Xs. Madhura Dhamangaonkar and Asian Games team gold winner Chikitha Taniparthi secured second and third places with 704 and 699, respectively.

While weather remained steady on a sunny day, wind tested the archers' skills.

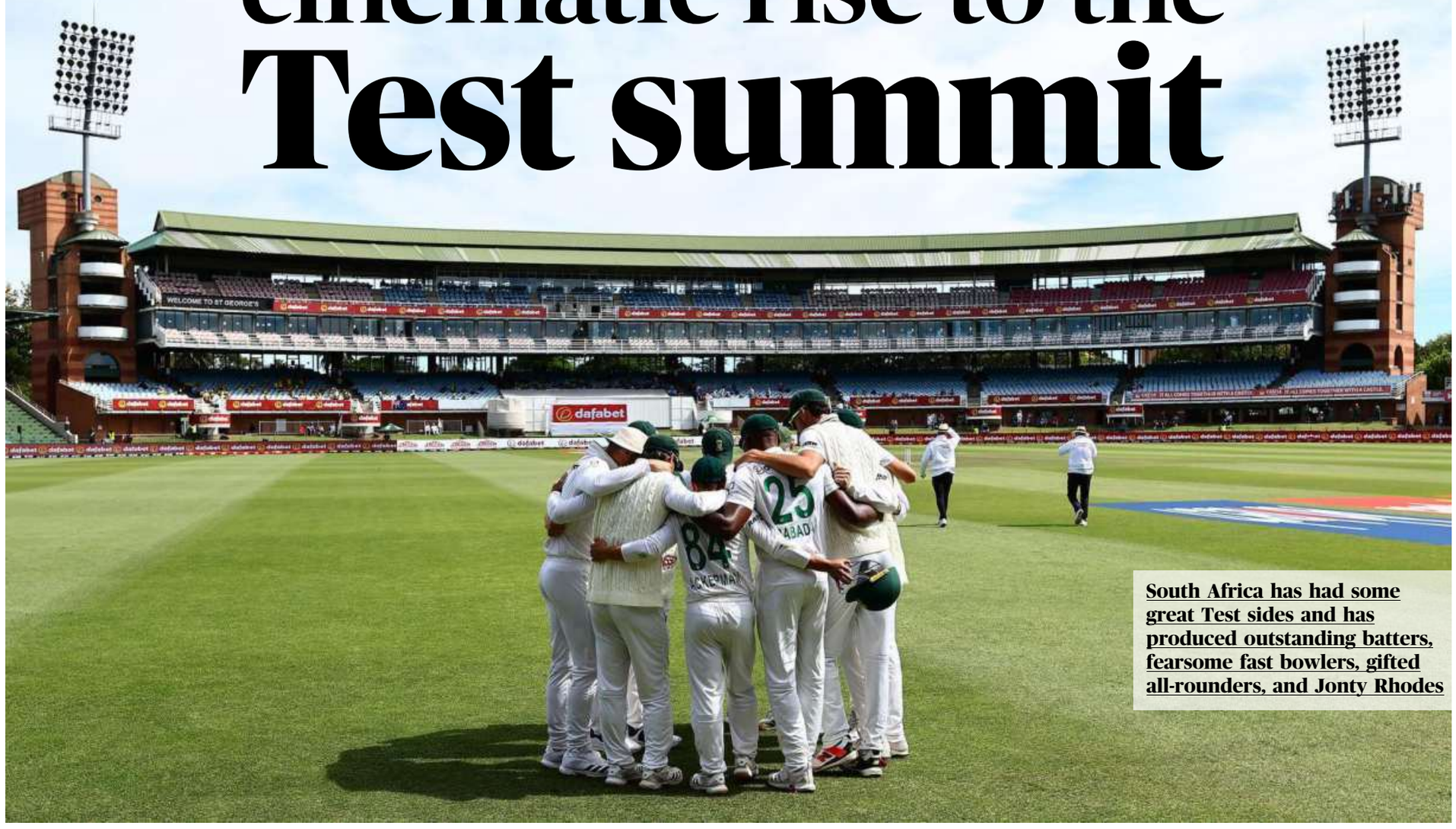


Proving their class: Priyansh and Parneet shone in windy conditions. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Parneet, who rectified an issue with her gripping earlier this year, overcame the disappointment of missing out on a berth in the Asian Games to record two identical segments of 355 and claim the top rank. Later, she guided the Punjab women's team to the final.

Important results: Compound: Individual: Qualification round: Men: 1. Priyansh (Del) 713, 2. Mohit Dagar (Har) 712, 3. Kushal Dalal (Har) 710, 4. Ojas Deotale (Mah) 707, 5. Prathamesh Fuge (Mah) 707, 7. Rajat Chauhan (AIP) 707, 8. Abhishek Verma (Del) 707, 14. Rishabh Yadav (Har) 704, 18. Sahil Jadhav (RSPB) 702. **Women:** 1. Parneet Kaur (Pun) 710, 2. Madhura Dhamangaonkar (Mah) 704, 3. Chikitha Taniparthi (Tel) 699, 4. Nishtha Gupta (UP) 699, 5. Vaidehi Jadhav (Mah) 698, 7. Priya Gurjar (Raj) 698, Muskan Kirar (MP) 697, 15. Pragati (Del) 692, 18. Avneet Kaur (Pun) 691. **Team: Elimination: Men: Semifinals:** Punjab bt Rajasthan 235-232, Madhya Pradesh bt RSPB 233-233 (28-27 via shoot-off); **Bronze medal match:** Rajasthan bt RSPB 234-233. **Women: Semifinals:** Uttar Pradesh bt Maharashtra 233-231, Punjab bt Delhi 233-226.

Invictus again: South Africa's cinematic rise to the Test summit



South Africa has had some great Test sides and has produced outstanding batters, fearsome fast bowlers, gifted all-rounders, and Jonty Rhodes

The Proteas, under Temba Bavuma and Shukri Conrad, hold both the World Test Championship and the No. 1 ranking — a position of affairs that seemed unimaginable in 2024 when a second-string side, a compromise because of the SA20's emergence, was thrashed by New Zealand

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Invictus must be one of the greatest films about sport. Because it is about much more than sport. It is about how Nelson Mandela saw the 1995 Rugby World Cup as an opportunity to unite a country where apartheid had only recently ended.

South Africa was hosting that World Cup. Mandela, the first black president of the country, was concerned that people of colour were not supporting the predominantly white Springboks ahead of the tournament. Morgan Freeman, one of the finest actors of our time, brought Mandela to life, while Matt Damon excelled as Springboks captain Francois Pienaar in the superbly crafted film directed by Clint Eastwood.

The opening scene

South Africa's ascent to the top of the Test rankings, following the series win against Australia a fortnight ago, has been a bit cinematic, too. The opening scene could well have been the circumstances relating to the selection of the South African team for the tour of New Zealand in early 2024.

India was touring South Africa at the time. The Proteas squad for the New Zealand series was announced after the innings victory in the first Test at Centurion. Only two players from that team, David Bedingham and Keegan Petersen, were booked on the flight to New Zealand. There were eight uncapped players, including the captain Neil Brand. That was because the senior players were contracted to feature in the SA20, South Africa's premier franchise league.

Bavuma has led this team from the front. Remarkably, under him, South Africa has won 13 out of 15 Tests

This was inevitably a topic when this writer met South Africa's coach Shukri Conrad for an interview ahead of the second Test at the magnificent Newlands ground in Cape Town. He was blunt. "We understand as cricketers that the SA20 league is hugely important," he said. "It brings in revenue, so that we can have more Test cricket in the future. But there could be a silver lining. And we might surprise a few people there."

They didn't surprise anyone. The South Africans lost the first Test by 281 runs and the second by seven wickets.

But, they haven't lost a series since. They won against the West Indies, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Zimbabwe, India and now Australia. The two-match series in Pakistan last year was drawn. The loss in Lahore was the only one until the 214-run defeat to Australia in the opening Test at Durban.

And yes, they also won the World Test Championship, beating Australia by five wickets at Lord's last year. And they lost the 'chokers' tag, as Aiden Markram and captain Temba Bavuma starred in the chase of 282, against the world's most prolific bowling attack of all time.

Not everyone was appreciative of South Africa's entry to the final, though. Former England captain Michael Vaughan claimed it reached the title clash on "the back of beating pretty much nobody". Kerry O'Keeffe, former Australian leg-spinner turned colourful commentator, was, well, more colourful in his criticism. He said South Africa's campaign was "like making the Wimbledon final without playing a seed on the way".

Conrad, however, begged to differ. "I am never going to apologise for getting into the final," he said. "It is the biggest thing for South African cricket at the moment."



TEMBA BAVUMA

SHUKRI CONRAD

GETTY IMAGES

Proving a point

Conrad's boys have since gone on to show that they can compete with, and beat, the top seeds. Winning both the Tests in India last year and now beating Australia in the three-match series after losing the first Test, they have proven a point or two. It is no fault of theirs that they do not meet the big three more regularly or do not play in series that have more than three Tests.

That is a pity, really. South Africa has had some great Test sides and has produced outstanding batters, fearsome fast bowlers, gifted all-rounders, and Jonty Rhodes. Some of the country's, and the world's, best talents, like Barry Richards, Graeme Pollock, Mike Procter and Garth Le Roux, were lost to the apartheid-era ban. South Africa played no international cricket between 1970 and 1990.

Not surprisingly, many South Africans moved to other countries and did well. There have been players like Tony Greig, Kepler Wessels, Allan Lamb, the Smith brothers Chris and Robin, Jonathan Trott, Devon Conway and Kevin Pietersen, who shifted his base to England after Ali Bacher, the then managing director of the United Cricket Board of South Africa, said that provincial teams would not field all-white sides.

South Africa may have lost some of its best players, but it has always unearthed exceptional talents like Jacques Kallis, A.B. de Villiers, Dale Steyn, Allan Donald, Graeme Smith, Shaun Pollock, Makhaya Ntini, Hashim Amla, Mark Boucher, Vernon Philander and Quinton de Kock.

South Africa had become the No. 1 Test team for the first time in 2012, and retained that ranking for 21 months till Australia took over. That side was led by Smith and featured players like Kallis, de Villiers, Amla, Steyn, Philander, Faf du Plessis and Morne Morkel.

Bavuma's team may not boast as many big stars, but in Kagiso Rabada it has an all-time great fast bowler. The world's No. 1 all-rounder (and No. 2 bowler) at the moment is his teammate Marco Jansen. The bowler who took 10 Australian wickets in the third Test is Simon Harmer, who had taken 17 wickets in the two Tests in India.

And it was centuries from Ryan Rickelton and Wiaan Mulder, coming in at No. 6 and No. 7, that ensured enough runs on the board for South Africa in the second innings. This South African side deserves to be the Word No. 1.

Bavuma has led this team from the front, too. Remarkably, under him, South Africa has won 13 out of 15 Tests. That the Rainbow Nation has achieved cricketing glory with two men of colour, Bavuma and Conrad, at the helm is significant.

Beating the odds

To go back to *Invictus* and the 1995 Rugby World Cup: South Africa beat the odds, and strong favourite New Zealand in the final, to lift the trophy at Johannesburg's Ellis Park Stadium in front of a crowd of 60,000, among whom was Mandela, wearing the No. 6 jersey (of Pienaar). That remains one of South African sport's greatest moments.

Martin Meredith wrote in his acclaimed biography of Mandela: "Never before had blacks had cause to show such pride in the efforts of their white countrymen. It was a moment of national fusion that Mandela had done much to inspire."

Winning the WTC and regaining the No. 1 ranking in Tests should also matter a lot for a country that takes pride in sporting achievements and culture, and that has loved its cricket even when it had, for a couple of decades, no hopes of playing an international game.

STACKING UP

ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Alexander Zverev	29	9,550	20
2	Jannik Sinner	25	9,450	17
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	7,100	18
4	Ben Shelton	24	5,170	22
5	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,820	24
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,680	25
7	Arthur Fils	22	3,625	20
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,390	23
9	Alex de Minaur	27	3,370	24
10	Taylor Fritz	29	3,285	23
11	Rafael Jodar	20	3,234	21
12	Novak Djokovic	39	2,940	15
13	Tommy Paul	29	2,925	23
14	F. Auger-Aliassime	26	2,865	21
15	Jiri Lehecka	25	2,540	22

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 264 ▲ 1 spot



Karan Singh
Rank 355 ▼ 1 spot

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	8,099	20
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	6,485	20
3	Mirra Andreeva	19	6,306	20
4	Coco Gauff	22	5,763	20
5	Jessica Pegula	32	5,760	20
6	Elina Svitolina	32	5,121	20
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,665	20
8	Linda Noskova	21	4,343	20
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,188	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,910	20
11	Diana Shnaider	22	3,238	23
12	Maja Chwalinska	25	3,016	23
13	Iva Jovic	18	2,941	23
14	Elise Mertens	30	2,540	23
15	Sorana Cirstea	36	2,386	22

Top Indians ▶



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 344 ▼ 10 spots



Vaidehee Chaudhari
Rank 392 ▲ 21 spots

English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Arsenal	10	9	0	1	15	5	10	27
2	Brighton	10	7	1	2	26	7	19	22
3	Man. City	10	7	0	3	21	13	8	21
4	Liverpool	10	5	3	2	14	10	4	18
5	Chelsea	10	5	1	4	19	16	3	16
6	Everton	10	4	4	2	12	10	2	16
7	Bournemouth	10	4	3	3	16	14	2	15
8	Brentford	10	3	5	2	16	11	5	14
9	Leeds United	10	3	5	2	10	8	2	14
10	Aston Villa	10	3	4	3	14	17	-3	13
11	Tottenham	10	3	3	4	10	11	-1	12
12	Newcastle	10	3	3	4	13	16	-3	12
13	Hull City	10	2	5	3	11	11	0	11
14	Ipswich Town	10	3	2	5	15	20	-5	11
15	Fulham	10	2	4	4	10	12	-2	10
16	N. Forest	10	2	3	5	9	13	-4	9
17	Coventry City	10	3	0	7	10	19	-9	9
18	Man. United	10	1	5	4	14	19	-5	8
19	Sunderland	10	2	2	6	8	17	-9	8
20	Crystal Palace	10	2	1	7	10	24	-14	7

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Lazio	11	9	2	0	25	9	16	29
2	Inter Milan	11	9	1	1	28	13	15	28
3	Roma	11	8	3	0	31	10	21	27
4	AC Milan	11	7	3	1	23	13	10	24
5	Como	11	7	2	2	18	10	8	23
6	Frosinone	11	6	2	3	24	15	9	20
7	Juventus	11	5	3	3	15	12	3	18
8	Bologna	11	5	2	4	16	14	2	17
9	Cagliari	11	5	1	5	10	15	-5	16
10	Napoli	11	4	3	4	18	14	4	15
11	Torino	11	4	2	5	15	17	-2	14
12	Atalanta	11	4	2	5	17	20	-3	14
13	Genoa	11	4	1	6	11	16	-5	13
14	Lecce	11	3	1	7	12	22	-10	10
15	Fiorentina	11	2	3	6	17	25	-8	9
16	Parma	11	2	2	7	9	17	-8	8
17	Sassuolo	11	2	2	7	16	29	-13	8
18	Monza	11	2	1	8	17	25	-8	7
19	Venezia	11	2	0	9	8	21	-13	6
20	Udinese	11	1	2	8	12	25	-13	5

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Barcelona	12	11	0	1	48	13	35	33
2	Real Madrid	12	10	0	2	31	10	21	30
3	Atletico Madrid	12	9	1	2	23	10	13	28
4	Real Betis	12	8	2	2	20	15	5	26
5	Real Sociedad	12	7	1	4	21	20	1	22
6	Sevilla	12	5	3	4	17	19	-2	18
7	Athletic Club	11	4	4	3	15	11	4	16
8	Villarreal	12	4	3	5	17	15	2	15
9	Deportivo	12	3	6	3	15	14	1	15
10	Racing Santander	12	4	2	6	17	30	-13	14
11	Celta Vigo	12	2	7	3	10	10	0	13
12	Alaves	12	3	4	5	15	17	-2	13
13	Espanyol	12	3	3	6	13	14	-1	12
14	Rayo Vallecano	11	3	3	5	15	21	-6	12
15	Getafe	12	3	3	6	8	18	-10	12
16	Osasuna	12	3	3	6	12	23	-11	12
17	Levante	12	2	5	5	16	21	-5	11
18	Elche	12	2	4	6	14	20	-6	10
19	Valencia	12	2	3	7	8	20	-12	9
20	Malaga	12	0	5	7	9	23	-14	5

German Bundesliga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Bayern	9	6	3	0	29	9	20	21
2	Dortmund	9	6	3	0	16	7	9	21
3	SC Freiburg	9	6	1	2	20	10	10	19
4	RB Leipzig	9	6	0	3	27	13	14	18
5	Leverkusen	9	5	1	3	20	17	3	16
6	Werder	9	4	3	2	17	15	2	15
7	Elversberg	9	4	1	4	17	18	-1	13
8	Stuttgart	9	4	0	5	15	15	0	12
9	Hoffenheim	9	4	0	5	16	17	-1	12
10	E. Frankfurt	9	3	3	3	15	20	-5	12
11	Hamburg	9	4	0	5	10	20	-10	12
12	Mainz	9	3	1	5	18	19	-1	10
13	Paderborn	9	2	4	3	8	11	-3	10
14	Augsburg	9	2	3	4	20	20	0	9
15	Cologne	9	2	3	4	10	14	-4	9
16	Union Berlin	9	1	4	4	7	21	-14	7
17	Schalke	9	1	3	5	5	11	-6	6
18	M'gladbach	9	1	1	7	12	25	-13	4

Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Joe Root	816	932
3	Travis Head	799	884
4	Temba Bavuma	793	818
5	Steve Smith	790	947
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rahmat Shah	735	735
8	Rishabh Pant	713	801
9	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
10	Shubman Gill	709	807

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	881	881
2	Marco Jansen	875	876
3	Matt Henry	861	870
4	Ollie Robinson	856	856
5	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
6	Scott Boland	821	829
7	Simon Harmer	817	817
8	Pat Cummins	789	914
9	Kagiso Rabada	801	902
10	Josh Hazlewood	785	864

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	822	855
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	781	908
4	Rohit Sharma	754	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	752	756
6	Ben Duckett	733	733
7	Shai Hope	710	782
8	Harry Brook	674	693
9	Babar Azam	661	894
10	K.L. Rahul	657	676

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	760	775
2	Keshav Maharaj	660	737
3	Abrar Ahmed	642	675
4	Mitchell Santner	621	656
4	Shaheen Afridi	621	691
6	A. Omarzai	610	610
7	Kuldeep Yadav	602	757
8	Mehidy Hasan	597	722
9	Taskin Ahmed	595	595
9	Maheesh Theekshana	595	680

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abhishek Sharma	889	931
2	Sahibzada Farhan	883	883
3	Ishan Kishan	862	916
4	Harry Brook	793	793
5	Jos Buttler	789	794
5	Dewald Brevis	789	806
7	Shreyas Iyer	777	829
8	Phil Salt	775	881
9	Shai Hope	759	766
10	Pathum Nissanka	720	796

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	731	828
2	Adam Zampa	700	746
3	Adil Rashid	695	747
3	Abrar Ahmed	695	757
5	Mitchell Santner	676	735
6	Nathan Ellis	675	678
7	Jamie Overton	674	674
8	Nasum Ahmed	661	661
9	Mahedi Hasan	654	654
10	Liam Dawson	648	652

A IN-X

GETTY IMAGES



The era of Collen: Kebinatshipi chases 400m immortality

The 22-year-old from Botswana followed last year's breakthrough at the World championships with a season of spectacular dominance. The 2027 Worlds, the 2028 Olympics and the one-lap world record are next on the agenda for athletics' rising superstar

Sports Bureau
Agence France-Presse

The 400m is one of the most fascinating events in athletics. Also known as the long sprint, it requires competitors to master every aspect of running, including the speed of the sprinter and the endurance of the half-miler.

The shorter sprints – the 100m and 200m – are tests of pace. The 400m, however, can have variations in how the race is run; athletes have to be aware of their competitors and respond to them. In addition to race strategy, 400m runners also have to put mind over matter in situations few other athletes have to contend with – once the lactic system is overwhelmed, 400m runners must continue sprinting hard despite their bodies urging them to slow down.

The greatest ever

Only truly exceptional athletes dominate the event. Among men, South Africa's Wayde van Niekerk owns the world record (43.03 seconds), Olympic gold (2016) and two World titles (2015 and 2017). American Michael Johnson, a four-time World champion and the only man to win back-to-back Olympic gold medals (1996 and 2000) in the discipline, held the world record for 17 years, and is widely considered the greatest to ever run the 400m.

> Winning Worlds 'early' didn't get in my head. This year was about putting my name up there and showing people who I am and what I'm capable of

Over the last 14 months, an athlete from Botswana has done enough to suggest that he might one day be spoken of in the same hushed tones.

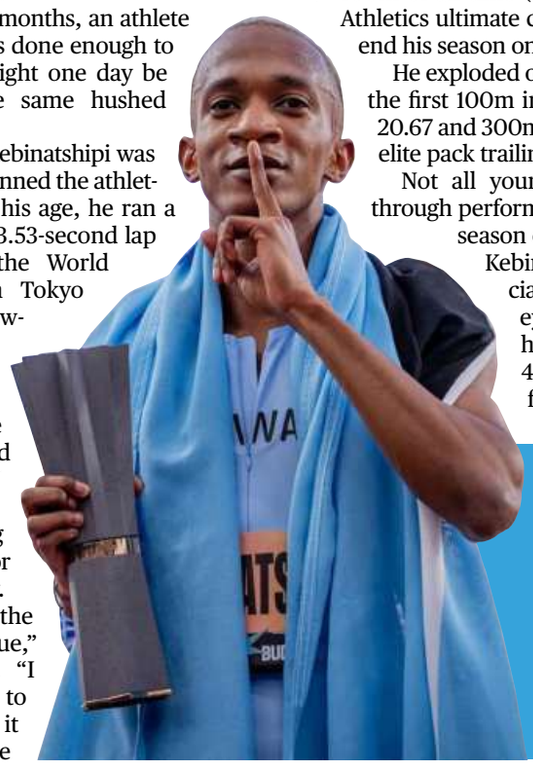
Busang Collen Kebinatshipi was 21 when he first stunned the athletics world: belying his age, he ran a perfectly judged 43.53-second lap to win gold at the World championships in Tokyo last year. He showcased maturity in not getting drawn into the unsustainable pace the early running had set and came off the final bend strongly, driving through the rain for a dominant victory.

"Getting gold is the dream come true," said Kebinatshipi. "I didn't expect it to come so early, but it shows that I'm able to do even more in the coming years."

He certainly has done "even more" in the year since that victory, staying invincible on the Diamond League circuit and running the fifth fastest 400m of all time (43.39) in winning the World Athletics ultimate championship in Budapest to end his season on a triumphant note.

He exploded off the blocks, tearing through the first 100m in 10.61, completing 200m in 20.67 and 300m in a searing 31.37, leaving an elite pack trailing in his wake.

Not all young athletes follow a breakthrough performance at a major event with a season of consistent dominance. But Kebinatshipi is clearly very special. In addition to September's eye-catching run at Budapest, he scorched to an impressive 43.40 in the Diamond League finals in Brussels, having also claimed top spot in Chorzow in August, Monaco and Eugene in July, Paris in June, and Xiamen in May. Six out of six in the Diamond League!



> Obviously [the world record of 43.03] is always running through my mind. If I go like 20.9 for the first 200, and then I go 22.0 or 22.1, it's going to give us a 42.9

The 22-year-old was also in rare form at the World Athletics relays at home in May. In a dream finish to two days of high-octane action in the Botswanan capital of Gaborone, Kebinatshipi came up with the goods in the 4x400m relay.

It was neck-and-neck between Botswana, South Africa and Australia at the final baton handover, but the reigning World champion decided to give his adoring home crowd a moment of magic. He broke free 40 metres from the line to win in a blistering 2min 54.47s, just 18 hundredths of a second slower than the world record set by a US quartet featuring Michael Johnson in 1993.

Built for the big stage

Kebinatshipi had also run a superb last leg in tricky, rain-drenched conditions at last year's World championships to win Botswana a historic 4x400m gold – this is evidently a man made for the biggest of stages and toughest of moments, an athlete supremely comfortable in his skin.

"Trust me," he told World Athletics in an interview after finishing the season. "This was just the start of an era of Collen. My plan is just to dominate for the longest period possible."

Next year's World championships, the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028 and the 400m world record are his three main goals in the near term. "Last year's win [at the Worlds] opened a lot of doors for me, but that was just the beginning, because this year was about putting my name up there and showing people who I am and what I'm capable of," he said.

"Winning Worlds 'early' didn't get in my head. Now, we go back to the drawing board for what we are aiming for – the 2028 Olympics. The world-record talks will be on the table, maybe in LA28. For now, I just want to make sure I stay healthy until the [2027] World championships."

Kebinatshipi isn't merely eyeing van Niekerk's 43.03: his sights are set on the first sub-43 run, even if he admits that there is still work to be done. Having extended his record for the most sub-44-second performances in a single season (six), while breaking the Diamond League record three times along the way, he knows what it takes to chase down a mark.

"Obviously it [the world record] is always running through my mind," said Kebinatshipi. "If I go like 20.9 for the first 200, and then I go 22.0 or 22.1, it's going to give us a 42.9. But with the world record, it hasn't been in our chat with my coach. We've just been discussing that we have to go season-by-season and, when I'm ready to run a good time, I'll push a good time."

The area Kebinatshipi has identified for improvement is the backstretch of the 400m. He describes himself as "still a bit light" and believes greater strength could help unlock his full potential. But his immediate focus is rest and recovery after a long, draining season.

Kebinatshipi blacked out not long after the ultimate championship in Budapest and had to spend several minutes recuperating in a wheelchair. "It's normal," he said. "I know every time I push my body, it's like that. The plan was to give everything, leave everything on the track."

Down time

Kebinatshipi's off-season is being spent on a 10-acre farm at home with his beloved boerboel dogs. "Unfortunately, they are not as fast as I am – they have big muscles and cannot keep up with me," he said. Not many can. It's why he thinks he still has "10, 11 years in this track life".

Having clocked a very impressive 9.89 seconds in the 100m this year, he fancies his chances in other events, too. "If we achieve what we want, run under 43 in the next five years, it'd give us another window to try another event," he said. "Once I accomplish it, in less than five years, I'm going to move to the 200m and after achieving what I want, I can skip again, go to the 800m."

GAME THEORY

Age just a number for Test's golden oldies

In the first Test between Zimbabwe and Afghanistan, which concluded in Sharjah on Monday, first Brendan Taylor and then Craig Ervine became two of the oldest male batters to reach three figures in cricket's classical format. A look at where they rank on the list of Test cricket's oldest century-makers:

Oldest batters to score a Test hundred

Rank	Player	Age	Team	Match start date
1	Jack Hobbs	46y 82d	England	8 Mar 1929
2	Patsy Hendren	45y 151d	England	6 Jul 1934
3	Warren Bardsley	43y 202d	Australia	26 Jun 1926
4	Dave Nourse	42y 291d	South Africa	12 Nov 1921
5	Frank Woolley	42y 61d	England	27 Jul 1929
6	Misbah-ul-Haq	42y 47d	Pakistan	14 Jul 2016
7	Eric Rowan	42y 6d	South Africa	26 Jul 1951
8	Bob Simpson	41y 359d	Australia	28 Jan 1978
9	Warwick Armstrong	41y 265d	Australia	11 Feb 1921
10	Tom Graveney	41y 263d	England	6 Mar 1969
11	Herbie Taylor	41y 241d	South Africa	1 Jan 1931
12	Bert Sutcliffe	41y 108d	New Zealand	5 Mar 1965
13	Craig Ervine	41y 78d	Zimbabwe	5 Nov 2026
14	Geoff Boycott	41y 63d	England	23 Dec 1981
15	Graham Gooch	40y 314d	England	2 Jun 1994
16	Brendan Taylor	40y 272d	Zimbabwe	5 Nov 2026

SOURCE: CRICINFO.COM | AGE AT THE START OF THE TEST (FOR THE LAST/MOST RECENT HUNDRED BY THE PLAYER)


JACK HOBBS


PATSY HENDREN


WARREN BARDSLEY


BRENDAN TAYLOR


CRAIG ERVINE

PICTURE THIS



GETTY IMAGES

Ice-capade

With winter about to make its presence felt in certain parts of the world, athletes of an icy persuasion have begun to anticipate the wonderland it opens up.

Notable among them are daredevil climbers, who seek to conquer a challenge like no other. Ice climbing is an enormously dangerous adventure sport that involves ascending routes made of frozen water. It evolved as a standalone skill from alpine climbing (rock, ice and snow) in the 1970s.

Climbing routes come in a variety of forms, including seasonally frozen waterfalls, high permanently frozen gullies and large hanging icicles. The discipline requires both specialised equipment, including double ice axes, ice tools, rigid crampons and steel ice screws, and rigorous training.

Climbers take care to ensure that the ice stays firm as they ascend, but the risk of the ice breaking is ever present. The seriousness of leading an ice climbing route is considered significantly greater than that of a traditional rock climbing route.

The sport's two major competitions are the World Cup and the World Championships.